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Servitizations influence on the Perceived Value of consumers in the Video Game Industry

A study of Full-Priced Live Service Titles

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Abstract

This master's thesis investigates the impact of servitization on consumer value perceptions within the video game industry, specifically focusing on the emergence of a hybrid model that combines elements of both Games-as-a-Product (GaaP) and Games-as-a-Service (GaaS). The research is part of an academic study on how hybrid business models affect consumer behaviour and perceived value in the context of full-priced live service titles.

Qualitative methods were employed, and empirical data was collected through semi-structured interviews with eight participants. Central to the study's methodology, these interviews were analyzed using the Gioia method, which helped identify first-order concepts, second-order themes, and aggregated dimensions. The research framework follows the Hamari, Hanner, and Koivisto (2020) model, which examines perceived value, continued use, and purchase intentions.

The findings of this study underscore the crucial role of transparency and fair pricing in maintaining consumer trust and loyalty. They reveal that continuous content updates enhance engagement and perceived quality, but also highlight the significant dissatisfaction that arises from high initial costs with additional monetization, as well as subpar initial quality. Participants emphasized the importance of transparency from developers throughout development and fair pricing for additional content to maintain trust and loyalty. This study provides crucial insights into balancing monetization practices with delivering comprehensive and enjoyable experiences, which is essential for fostering positive consumer perceptions and sustaining long-term engagement. This thesis not only contributes to the broader understanding of servitization in digital markets but also proposes practical implications for developers and publishers in all industries. It underscores the need for transparent communication and fair pricing strategies to enhance consumer satisfaction and loyalty, offering a nuanced view of the benefits and challenges associated with the hybrid live service model.

Keywords Continuous development, perceived value, Games-as-a-Service, hybrid model, consumer behavior, monetization strategies, video game industry, live service titles

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1. INTRODUCTION: Hybridization of Business Models

1.1 Background

The video game industry is one of the largest industries in the world, with different mediums that allow users to play however they wish. Having earned 184 billion dollars in 2023, 49% of which comes from mobile devices alone, the industry continues to grow year on year (Newzoo, 2024). The industry has even evolved past video games with the growing popularity of live streaming and tournaments, establishing the industry as an "entertainment juggernaut" (Mizra, 2019). Unsurprisingly, like many business sectors, digital disruption has affected the industry and its operations, primarily through shifting business models. Traditionally, consumers would pay a set price for the complete use of a title and its features, commonly known as the play-to-play model or the Games-as-a-Product (GaaP) model. While this model is still used today, the growth of digital offerings over the past decade has led to more service-centered models, such as the free-to-play or Games-as-a-service (GaaS) models (Davidovici-Nora, 2013; Chua et al., 2019). Such a shift towards servitization has led to a player-focused model based on providing updates, recurring revenue, and player retention instead of a one-time purchase (Dubois and Weststar, 2021).

The shifting landscape of business models within the industry has led to a hybridization of GaaP and GaaS, with full-priced titles being released with features commonly found in free GaaS titles. At the same time, there are benefits for developers, such as expanding the offerings of the title past release, widening the player base, and increasing revenue (Davidovici-Nora, 2013 & Marchand and Thurau, 2013). Simultaneously, the shift has led to many controversies regarding monetization and, more recently, the discussion of full-priced titles released in an unfinished state, with the promise of being fixed with subsequent content releases and updates (Vaudour and Heinze, 2019). These aforementioned practices often lead to consumer dissatisfaction, as players pay for what is deemed an incomplete product, harming trust in developers and publishers. Additionally, this approach can create a perception that companies prioritize profits over delivering a complete and polished game, further damaging brand reputation. Recent titles such as Call of Duty: Modern Warfare 3 (2023), Suicide Squad: Kill the Justice

League (2024), and Battlefield 2042 (2022) all employed the hybrid model with backlash from consumers. While perceived value within the GaaS model has been discussed before, with a strong focus on the monetization practices seen in them, such as cosmetic skins and content subscriptions (Theodora and Napitupulu, 2023 & Hamari, Hanner and Koivisto, 2019). There needs to be more focus on the perceived value of titles and how such a hybridization has affected customers' purchasing behaviour.

Understanding consumer value perception in the video game industry, particularly under the hybrid model that has begun to emerge, is crucial. Perceived value is defined as the consumer's overall assessment of the utility of a product based on perceptions of what is received and what is given (Zeithaml, 1988). However, it encompasses economic value and emotional, social, and quality aspects (Sweeney & Soutar, 2001). Under the guise of the video game industry, this multidimensional approach suggests that consumers evaluate video games not just on their monetary cost but also on their emotional satisfaction, social connectivity, and the quality of gameplay they offer. As more titles under this hybrid model are released, consumers are then forced to evaluate these titles under a new paradigm. Now, the titles are based not only on the immediate gameplay, the plot, or the way a game is played but also on the offerings given through the in-game stores and the potential lifecycle of a title. While this can enhance consumer engagement, it also introduces the risk of alienating potential players if there is no balance between paid content and core gameplay experiences. Prior research has shown that the unsuccessful implementation of such features can lead to decreased satisfaction with a title and, as mentioned above, can result in backlash from the gaming community, impacting sales and long-term brand loyalty (Ball & Fordham, 2018). In order to implement such a hybrid model, a balance needs to be struck, ensuring that consumers feel they receive fair value both at the initial purchase and throughout the product's lifecycle.

The significance of this study lies in its exploration of the evolving landscape of the video game industry, particularly the implications of the hybridization of business models. More research needs to be completed regarding business models in video games outside of

the monetization practices seen within them. By analyzing this research gap, developers, producers, and consumers alike will gain valuable insights into the industry and the effects of digitalization on value perceptions of video game titles. Furthermore, the findings from this study could have implications that apply beyond the video game industry. Similar hybrid models are also emerging in other business sectors, and understanding how these models affect consumer value perceptions could provide valuable information for these industries to enhance their customer engagement and optimize their business models. This broader relevance highlights the importance of this research, showing its potential to enhance our understanding of digital consumer behaviour and business strategy across various service-oriented industries.

1.2 Research Problem

A common trend can be seen when examining the video game industry and the research conducted concerning business models. Primarily, it focuses on the monetization practices that have become common in many free-to-play or freemium titles (Davidovici-Nora, 2013, Alha et al., 2014). It should be stated that studies related to Free-to-Play and Freemium games can be applied to GaaS due to the similar nature of the business models in terms of content offerings. In spite of the fact that there has been plenty of research on the monetization practices commonly seen in GaaS, more research needs to be aimed at how the evolution of said business models has affected the purchasing behaviour of titles themselves. Hsiao and Chen (2016) and Hamari et al. (2019) studied purchase intentions of in-game monetization with a focus on perceived value. Monetization is a core offering within games of the hybrid model, though how this affects the perceived value of the title itself needs further analysis. Furthermore, Hussain et al. (2023) analyzed the value co-creation of premium services in free-to-play titles through value-added services, allowing for greater customization of their desired ways to play and interact with a title. Nonetheless, there is still a substantial gap in knowledge regarding how users perceive titles and the value given to them by the hybrid model, which has become prevalent in the industry. While much of the insights gained from previous research still apply to the emerging model, shifts within an industry must still be analyzed as it grows and adopts new digital practices.

Research conducted by He (2021) found that GaaS as a whole does not guarantee success for all games and that it can, in actuality, hurt a title that did not require such a model in the first place. However, the industry continues to release titles using such a hybrid model. Similarly, research into the video game industry continues to overlook a critical aspect of the industry that has started to be more prominent than before. While previous research has shed light on the effects of in-game monetization and premium services offered, the long-term effects of the ongoing development of GaaP titles – characterized within the hybrid model – remain unexplored. Continuous development, which entails regular updates, new content releases, and iterative improvement, inherently alters the industry landscape—redefining value propositions for consumers with a focus on evolving services rather than a tailored product. This shift towards continued engagement presents a unique research opportunity: understanding how the trend of continuous development has changed the perceived value of titles.

Quantitative data collection methods such as surveys are the standard methodology for data collection conducted by research within the gaming industry. Such methods have their own strengths with larger data values; however, they can produce unreliable data, as respondents may need to be more forthcoming about habits as they may be perceived as unfavorable (Duffy et al., 2005). Therefore, for the purpose of this thesis, a qualitative approach was selected for data collection to obtain a deeper understanding of consumers' purchase intentions. More specifically, semi-structured interviews were chosen as interviewees were treated as educated individuals on the research topic, opening avenues for more in-depth responses. Convenience sampling was conducted as well, as the interviewer was already acquainted with each participant prior to the beginning of this thesis process. Participants in the interviews were all male, aged 20 to 27 years old. Additionally, all participants have had a long history of playing video games, making them ideal candidates for this study.

1.3 Research Questions

The research questions of this thesis were designed to address the core research problem of this thesis, focusing on how the prominence of hybrid models and continuous developments impacts consumer perceived value:

1. How do consumers perceive the value of games offered under the hybrid live service model?
2. How does the release of games as unfinished goods with promises of continued development influence consumers' perceptions of value and their subsequent trust and loyalty towards game developers and publishers?

Answering these research questions will help address this thesis's research problem by analyzing how the prominence of hybrid models and continuous development impacts consumer perceptions.

1.4 Research Objectives

The research objectives of this thesis were chosen to support the research that is being conducted. Additionally, these objectives were selected to formulate relevant research questions that support the theories of the thesis. The research objectives set for this thesis are:

1. To investigate the influence of hybrid models and continuous development on consumer value perceptions of video games.
2. To examine the effect of continuous development on consumer behaviour, such as purchase intentions and engagement, within hybrid models.
3. To outline which components of continuous development shapes consumer perceptions of value in hybrid models.

The research objectives are crucial in exploring how the hybrid model and their continuous development practices influence consumer purchasing behaviour and

engagement. Through this investigation, the thesis aims to shed light on the broader implication of game design and business model evolution on consumer behaviour.

1.6 Structure of Thesis

This thesis is structured to provide a comprehensive analysis of consumer perceptions of value concerning the hybridization of business models within the Video Game Industry. The following section consists of the literature review, which will discuss the previous research conducted concerning the industry and address the research gaps. The methodology section outlines the thesis's research design, encompassing the data collection and analysis methods. Then, the findings will analyze the collected primary data, offering insights into consumer perceptions. This will be followed by the discussions section, which will interpret the findings of the collected primary data through the lens of the previously conducted research and evaluate their implications. Finally, the thesis will conclude with the conclusion section that summarizes the discussed findings, how they relate to information systems, and makes suggestions for further research.

2. LITERATURE REVIEW

This literature review aims to illuminate the dynamics between consumer value perceptions and the integration of GaaS features within full-priced releases in the video game industry. Its focus is on understanding how the hybridization of the more traditional GaaP model, through game design and monetization strategies, influences consumer motivations and perceptions of value. Scholarly articles on video game business models, player engagement mechanisms, and consumer purchasing motivations shape the foundation of this analysis.

2.1 Evolution of Video Game Business Models

The video game industry is one of the world's most extensive entertainment industries, earning a total of 184 billion USD in revenue in 2023 alone and a predicted amount of 205.4 Billion USD in 2026. Furthermore, more people are finding different ways to play their favorite titles, with a total of 3.3 billion players in 2023, 2.7 billion of which are playing on their mobile devices (Newzoo, 2024). The past few decades of development in the

video game industry have highlighted this growth with various transformations in how games are monetized and delivered to customers. The best-selling and highest-grossing games in 2022 were Call of Duty: Modern Warfare 2 and Candy Crush: Saga, respectively, both games being offered on differing platforms and employing their business models (Theesa, 2023). Even though it has established itself as an entertainment juggernaut, the industry has continued to experience continuous disruption that affects its business models, distribution, and consumption since its rise in the 1980s.

Business models, like the video game industry, were affected by digitalization, initially being explained in terms of the customer, what is valued, and how revenue is gained. With digital disruption, business models have developed toward design choices concerning value networks, functional architecture, and value propositions toward users (Komorowski & Delaere, 2016). Such parallels can be seen in the video game industry's growth since its initial success in the 1980s. Changes in computer architecture allowed for an increase in processing power as a result of smaller and more inexpensive computers; serial production for personal at-home computers then became a reality. This resulted in video games becoming the first software products offered directly to users and with the traditional Pay-to-play business model (Tomic, 2017; Marchand & Thurau, 2013). Pay to play, for the purposes of this paper GaaP, held the basic principle of selling the entire game to the customer at once, where the customer paid a total price to install the game onto their computer at a premium price. While the GaaP model is still in use today, within the past two decades, there has been a growing shift away from this model, which has been attributed to the variety of ways to play and the large volume of content that can be consumed year on year (Marchand & Thurau, 2013).

Massive Multiplayer Online games, hereinafter MMOs, started to grow in popularity in the 90s with the release of titles such as Neverwinter Nights and would not reach mainstream popularity until the release of titles such as Activision Blizzard's World of Warcraft. Titles such as World of Warcraft allowed players access to the title with an internet connection through digital downloads and purchasing a monthly subscription (Dillon, 2013). A monthly subscription marked the first shift from GaaPas. However, trends within the

communities of these MMOs can be seen as the birth of free-to-play, as mentioned by Davidovici-Nora (2013). More specifically, the trend of Real Money Trades can be noted as the first microtransactions seen within the industry. RMTs began with players spending real money for items in the game through third-party systems. In order to circumvent these transactions, titles such as World of Warcraft revised their business plan by integrating in-game shops, creating an internal economy within the title (Komorowski & Delaere, 2016; Davidovici-Nora, 2013). Gradually, many titles shifted their business plans to free-to-play due to various motivations, which were noted by Davidovici-Nora (2013): to continue the life cycle of an intellectual property, to boost the number of players after a failed launch, to allow for more casual players to enter an already established player base, and to obtain more business and financial opportunities for an already successful franchise

Komorowski and Delaere (2016) and Dillion (2017) reinforce these claims with various factors enforcing the shift from free-to-play primarily to capture higher value for players compared to subscription-based models. Freemium games, which offer a limited demo requiring the purchase of a subscription to unlock additional content, also became a prominent alternative to the subscription (ibid). However, the growing focus on increasing a product's life cycle has led to the growth of sterilization within the industry, which entails the development and now predominant use of the GaaS model.

GaaS titles are games determined by the strategy implemented in their long-term development. Instead of releasing a new standalone title or sequel to a successful release, incremental content releases and tweaks to gameplay mechanics are released (Alha et al., 2017; Bubois & Weststar, 2021). While features such as downloadable content (Hereinafter DLC) have been widespread within the lifecycles of gaming titles for decades and have been employed in many GaaP titles, GaaS marks a notable shift as it draws many servitization trends seen in manufacturing. Notably shifting away from after-sale offerings, previously seen in the industry with DLC, and focusing on a product-service systems highlighting the entire product lifecycle. More specifically, GaaS is a player-centric model based on updates, recurring customer acquisition, retention, and

monetization, which was seen to positively impact digital game performance (Aleem, Capretz and Ahmed, 2016; Buboid & Weststar, 2021). Though the model has become commonplace within the industry, there has been a growing trend of its implementation within full-priced releases in recent years. The creation of this hybrid model has caused backlash from players for various reasons.

Examining the evolution of video game business models is crucial for understanding the shifting dynamics within the industry, impacting both consumer behaviour and market strategies. Underpinning the transition from the traditional GaaP model to the prominence of GaaS shed light on the importance of ongoing engagement and revenue generation through continuous updates and in-game purchases. This evolution mirrors broader trends in digital consumption, where the value of a product extends past the initial purchase to include ongoing user experiences and interactions through updates. For the purpose of this thesis, it is vital to highlight the influence of consumer perception of value and purchasing behaviours through these models. The implication beyond this offers insights into other digital and service-oriented sectors, such as industries such as software, media streaming, and even vehicles that adopt comparable hybrid models. This broader relevance underscores the importance of studying the evolution of business models, making it a critical component of the thesis. The following section will analyze how these GaaS features have been implemented into full-priced titles, examining the specific strategies and their implications for developers and consumers.

2.2 Integration of GaaS Features in Full-Priced Games

Integrating GaaS features into full-priced GaaP titles is not just a trend but a strategic evolution within the video game industry. GaaS's approach has not only proven popular amongst players, more specifically in terms of PC gaming, but also profitable for companies (He, 2021). For instance, *Fortnite*, the free-to-play battle royale title released by publisher Epic Games, is a prime example of how lucrative GaaS can be. Despite not reaching its peak of 5.4 billion dollars in 2018, *Fortnite* still generated 4.4 billion dollars in revenue in 2022. (Iqbal, 2023). Moreover, a significant portion of gaming activity highlights the long-term engagement facilitated by GaaS; in 2023, 25% of all playtime was attributed

to service titles that had been on the market for six or more years (Newzoo, 2024). With the success of titles under the GaaS structure, it is no wonder that there has been an increasing trend in titles utilizing a hybrid model.

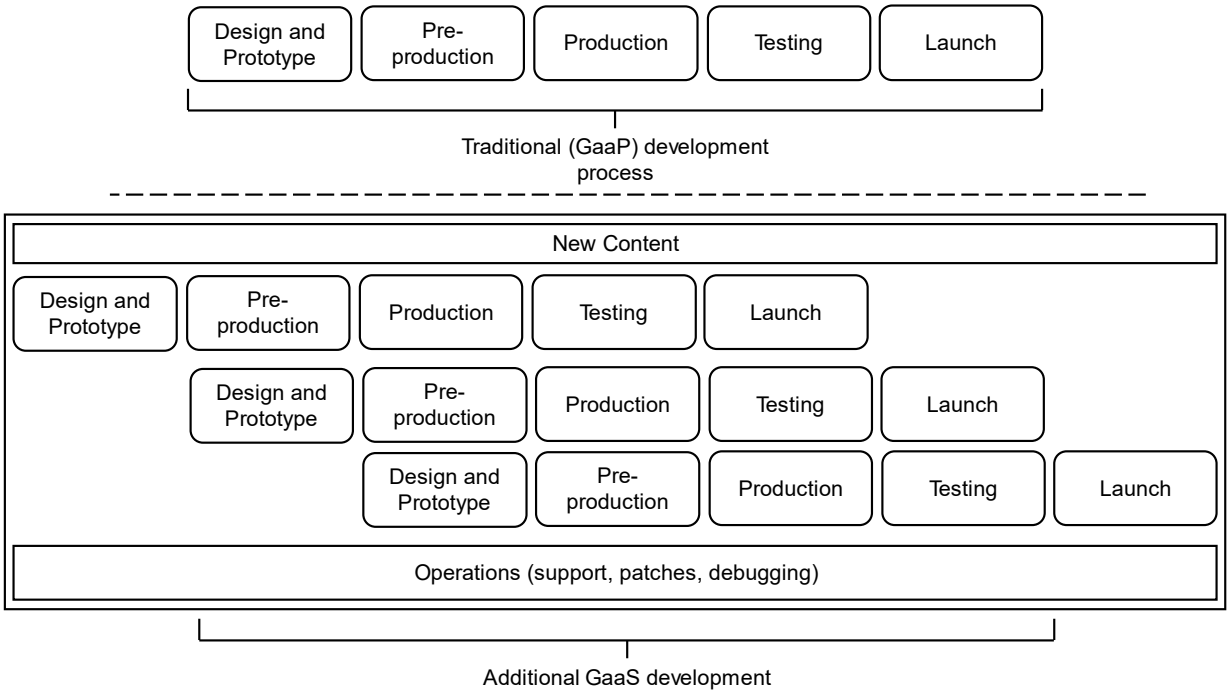

Figure 1. GaaP versus GaaS development lifecycles (Dubois & Weststar, 2021).

The hybrid model for the purpose of this paper refers to the recent trend of full-priced titles, as seen with GaaP, that employs a service model, as seen with GaaS. The distinction must be made as many developers have and continue to offer updates to titles and DLC expansions for many years. For example, the 2008 title *Grand Theft Auto IV* had two expansions that offered several hours of additional story content for users at a third of the price of the main title (Sotamaa & Karppi, 2010). More recently, titles such as *The Witcher 3: The Wild Hunt* offered two expansions for additional content and a significant quality-of-life update in 2022 for next-generation consoles seven years after its original release in 2015 (Webster, 2022). While many games apply the development processes of live service games mentioned by Dubois & Weststar (Figure 1), the new live

service model initially deploys buying into a product that has the monetization focus and post-launch development of live service games.

The transformative impact of GaaS and its hybrid model on the gaming industry is undeniable, affecting developers, publishers, and players in numerous ways. For developers, the model allows the release of an unfinished product, which, if well-received, can be refined and expanded through DLCs and updates, as seen in additional GaaS development in Figure 1, thus optimizing further investment based on player feedback (Vaudour and Heinze, 2019). Marketing and communication strategies also become more streamlined as CRM systems simplify community engagement, making adapting updates in response to user demands easier. Additionally, monetization through this model ensures a consistent revenue flow, often surpassing earnings from initial sales or subscriptions (Aleem, Capretz, and Ahmed, 2016). This approach significantly extends a title's lifecycle, diminishing the pressure to develop new releases rapidly. In fact, Theodora and Napitupulu (2023) found that the events, which commemorate a milestone of the title, generally in the form of a content release or update, create additional engagement for users and increase the perceived credibility of the developer, leading to the purchasing of content offerings.

The development practices of this hybrid model have been found to create opportunities for co-creation with users, as seen in the study completed by Hussain et al. (2023). More specifically, aspects such as updated gaming features include superior game functionality, competitive game design, personalization, and self-indulgence. Additionally, the feeling of being heard through listening to player feedback was seen as a driver for co-creation as well, which is a cornerstone of a live service model as described by Vadour & Heinze (2019). However, there are controversies surrounding the hybrid model. Lehtonen, Vesa, and Harviainen (2021) found many aspects of the live service paradigm to create value co-destruction as opposed to co-creation. Regarding development practices, they design play as labor without the support of additional purchases and closure denial; no conclusive end to the title leads to dissatisfaction with the service model. Similar findings were highlighted by Vadour & Heinze (2019) and He (2021), who

also found that the incomplete nature of titles generated a general feeling of a tarnished gaming experience.

Furthermore, within the live service paradigm, the general cost, through microtransactions, after incremental updates would outweigh the more traditional GaaP service. Within the hybrid model, this would mean the consumer has purchased the product with the additional content promised by the developer not being available on day one. The game is then the equivalent of a pre-emptive experience version (He, 2019). Moreover, Petrovskaya and Zendle (2021) found the release of an incomplete product an example of predatory monetization of products, delivering a product that does not meet the expectations created by the developer. Furthermore, this leads to the title being a monopoly of the player's time, as the player cannot take care of many live service titles simultaneously. Though the GaaS business model has proven successful, such as with the previously mentioned *Fortnite*, they are designed with monetization in mind, as Alha et al. (2014) and Davidovici-Nora (2013) stated. The offerings within these titles allow consumers to spend money based on the developer's design. The reasoning for this comes from the idea that purchasing in-game content will create greater profits than the initial base price of the game (ibid). Where games under this new hybrid model begin to create controversy is the fact that the initial purchase seen within GaaP titles is required.

As the hybridization of GaaP and GaaS continues within the industry, it is essential to put perspective on how this has evoked the creation of a hybrid model, combining the traditional one-time purchase with ongoing service elements. More specifically, elements such as continuous content updates and in-game purchases extend the titles' lifecycle and engagement potential. Understanding this integration is vital as it highlights both the opportunities and challenges developers and publishers face in balancing initial offerings within a title with long-term monetization strategies. For this research, examining these factors provides vital insights into how the emergence of this hybrid model influences value, satisfaction, and loyalty. It emphasizes the need for a balance in quality, ensuring that players receive fair value within the initial purchase and continued life cycle of the

game. Understanding this balance is crucial for the video game industry and other sectors adopting service-oriented models. Monetization is another crucial aspect of both GaaS and the hybrid model, and how monetization is handled will be discussed in the following section.

2.3 Monetization in Games

As stated in the previous section, monetization is at the core of the Games as a Service (GaaS) model. It is also evident in the new hybrid model, which combines elements of traditional full-priced games with ongoing service-based updates. Vadour & Heinze (2019) stated that several revenue streams generally employed in GaaS are those of subscriptions, season passes, microtransactions, and advergaming. The most common form of monetization employed after the initial purchase of a title is optional purchases, known as microtransactions, defined by Call & Fordman (2018) as in-game purchases that unlock content for a game with prices ranging from .99 cents to hundreds of dollars. According to Švelch (2017), full-priced developers and publishers traditionally adopt microtransactions to create an alternative revenue stream through market convergence. As it is an integral aspect of the hybrid model, which combines the initial purchase with ongoing microtransactions, it is important to analyze the perception of their implementation into titles. The following section will delve into microtransactions and their effect on video game design.

As stated previously, the earliest form of microtransactions came from the transaction of virtual goods between players in MMOs such as World of Warcraft, which further evolved into subscription fees and expansion packs (Chua et al, 2019; Hamari and Lehdonvirta, 2010). Though these offered users access to additional content, microtransactions shifted towards the purpose of speeding up the process of playing games for users who did not have the time to play compared to others (Nielson, 2018). Utilizing microtransactions in this fashion was deemed as pay-to-win, as it allowed others to pay for a competitive advantage over others, which was deemed unfair by Hamari et al. (2017). Furthermore, Hamari et al. (2017) found that service developers have faced a dilemma when balancing high-quality service with creating a sufficient demand for the premium microtransactions

that augment the core service of the title. Hamari's 2010 research introduced the reason for such a dilemma: players are less likely to spend real money to augment the core service offerings of a game when they enjoy the core service. Artificial barriers were then implemented to urge players to purchase those additional offerings. Such obstacles were referenced by Lehtonen, Vesa, and Harviainen (2021) in terms of designing play as labor. Early attempts to implement the hybrid model into full-priced titles saw backlash due to the play-to-play nature of the entries. More specifically, titles such as Electronic Arts Star Wars Battlefront 2 and Ubisoft's Assassin's Creed: Origins (ball and Fordham, 2018). Within research, the implementation of this has been noted to not only hurt sales but also be declared unethical (Hiemo et al., 2016; Ball & Fordham, 2018).

Nevertheless, monetization has become a focal point in the development of games, being integrated into all aspects of creation (Švelch and Van Roessel, 2019). The content offerings commonly given can be split into two categories through mechanisms for functionality and aesthetics (Ho, 2014). This is done by creating commercial value within game design, with functional microtransactions lowering the necessity of effort and being complemented by aesthetic microtransactions, creating stronger relationships for the user. Contrastingly, Hamari (2010) highlighted marketing tactics that developers have employed to create a necessity for purchasing microtransactions item degradation, inconvenient gameplay elements, in-game mediums of exchange, inventory mechanics, special promotional occasions, artificial scarcity, and alterations to existing content. However, Hamari (2010) echoed similar findings concerning Ho's (2014) statements on the importance of the players' appearance and the functionality of items.

GaaS and the hybrid model have begun to move towards a focus on aesthetic microtransactions, with all additional content offerings being provided through more extensive free updates. Backlash from what was deemed predatory practices, as referenced by Call and Fordham (2018), is the motivation for this. In terms of the live service hybrid model, a seasonal pass model is implemented, commonly known as a battle pass (He, 2021). The battle pass itself allows players access to limited-time content

for the duration of an in-game season. Furthermore, an in-game store has additional cosmetics that allow players to buy more items through the use of in-game currency.

An analysis of monetization strategies in games, especially in the context of hybrid live service models, is important for understanding how these practices can influence behaviour and perceptions. Microtransactions, season passes, and other in-game offerings have become integral to modern game design, significantly affecting how players perceive value and purchasing behaviour. This section highlighted the intricate balance developers must achieve between monetization and maintaining a satisfying gameplay experience, as aggressive or predatory monetization can lead to consumer backlash and diminished trust. In relation to this study, understanding these monetization strategies offers insight into their impact on consumer engagement, satisfaction, and loyalty. These findings apply to the videogame industry and offer valuable lessons to other sectors enacting their own monetization strategies. The broader relevance underscores the importance of studying these practices to enhance consumer value perception and optimize business models. Building on this analysis, the following section will delve into consumer value perceptions of digital products, providing a deeper understanding of the factors driving consumer behaviour in the digital age and further informing the implications of hybrid business models.

2.4 Consumer Value Perception in Digital Products

Understanding consumer value perceptions is critical in the current digital economy, where intangible products such as software and video games provide differing value compared to physical goods due to their intangibility, customization, and scalability. Consumers primarily assess value based on factors such as functionality, provider reputation, and user reviews due to the unique attributes of these digital goods (Kim et al., 2011). The following section will explore how these perceptions affect video games due to various offerings given to users through GaaS and, in turn, the new hybrid live service model.

As digital markets continue to expand, interest in purchasing behaviour has also grown. When creating a product, especially in a digital environment, it is essential to analyse how consumers perceive the value of available offers. Perceived value, defined by Lovelock and Wirtz (2021), states that perceived value is the value customers get by comparing perceived benefits with perceived costs. Aside from monetary value, Sweeney and Soutar (2001) found that emotional, social, and quality factors also influenced perceived value. Emotional factors equate to the feelings a product elicits, such as joy or excitement. Social factors involve perceived social benefits from owning a said product. Quality pertains to a product's perceived excellence in features and performance. Studies into virtual goods and e-commerce had similar findings, with the addition of functionality playing a role in how consumers value a product and their role in purchase intentions (Kim et al., 2011; Kim, 2012).

Additionally, perceived risk was researched by Kamalul Ariffin, Mohan, and Goh (2018), where social risk was deemed insignificant in online purchasing. Furthermore, while product price was found to affect the perceived quality of a product positively, a higher price was seen to negatively affect product value (Ibid); while these studies analyze digital e-commerce and value perceptions in general, the study of perceived value concerning video games focuses primarily on the purchasing of additional content, as mentioned in the previous section on monetization in video games.

A study completed by Coursaris, Osch, and Sese (2016) found that certain game features coupled with player motivation present a strong motivation for both continued use and purchase intention of products concerning video games. More specifically, game features include connectiveness, bonding, and share-in features. Connection is sharing progress with individuals while bonding through in-game interactions and share-in features, allowing for personal customization and individual representation (Ibid). Similar yet contradictory findings were seen from research conducted by Hsiao and Chen (2016) in their study on perceived value's effect on purchase intentions in mobile games. Their findings called attention to the fact that users who had paid and users who had yet to pay

for additional content did not find these features influenced their purchase intentions. However, they did create a solid loyalty to the titles, which led to purchasing intentions.

Finally, research conducted by Hamari, Hanner, and Koivisto (2021) on "Why pay premium in freemium services?" analyzed the value perceptions of users and their effect on continued use and purchase intentions. Within their definition of perceived value, enjoyment, social value, quality, and economics all played a role in forming the totality of an individual's value of a product. Their findings underscored that the quality and the economic value of premium content did not affect the purchase intentions of said content. Moreover, all aspects of perceived value lead to continuous use of a product, which has a more significant role in the purchase intention of premium content. Similar results were seen in Mäntymäki, Islam, and Benbasat's (2020) research, though price value, similar to economic value, did play a role in retaining the premium subscription. Furthermore, the additional features provided by premium content did influence purchases.

Consumer value perceptions in digital products, especially video games, reveal multifaceted influences on perceived value through functionality, emotional engagement, social interactions, and economic considerations. As seen in various studies, while traditional economic metrics shape perceived value, additional factors like enjoyment, social connectivity, and the customization features of video games often hold more substantial sway over consumer behaviour. These elements not only drive continued engagement of a service but also influence purchases within digital marketplaces. Though these studies focused primarily on free-to-play titles, understanding the implication of these findings plays a crucial role in the emergence of the hybrid live service model. Perceived value now plays an even more vital role in purchases, as an additional premium payment is required for these service titles.

An overall understanding of consumer value perception is essential in the digital economy, where intangible products such as video games offer unique value propositions through functionality, customization, and engagement. Considering the various factors influencing consumer perception of value, including emotional engagement, social

interactions, and economic consideration, a clear view of divers can be perceived. With this study in mind, viewing consumer value perceptions provides a more nuanced understanding of the factors that influence purchasing behaviour and ongoing product engagement. Recognizing the implications of these findings outside of the video game industry, monetizing and delivering value to consumers requires a careful balance to foster loyalty and trust in the long term.

Building on this analysis, as seen in the figure below, this thesis's conceptual framework is grounded in the research model developed by Hamari, Hanner, and Koivisto (2020), which analyzed the relationships between perceived value, continued use intentions, and purchase intentions of digital goods.

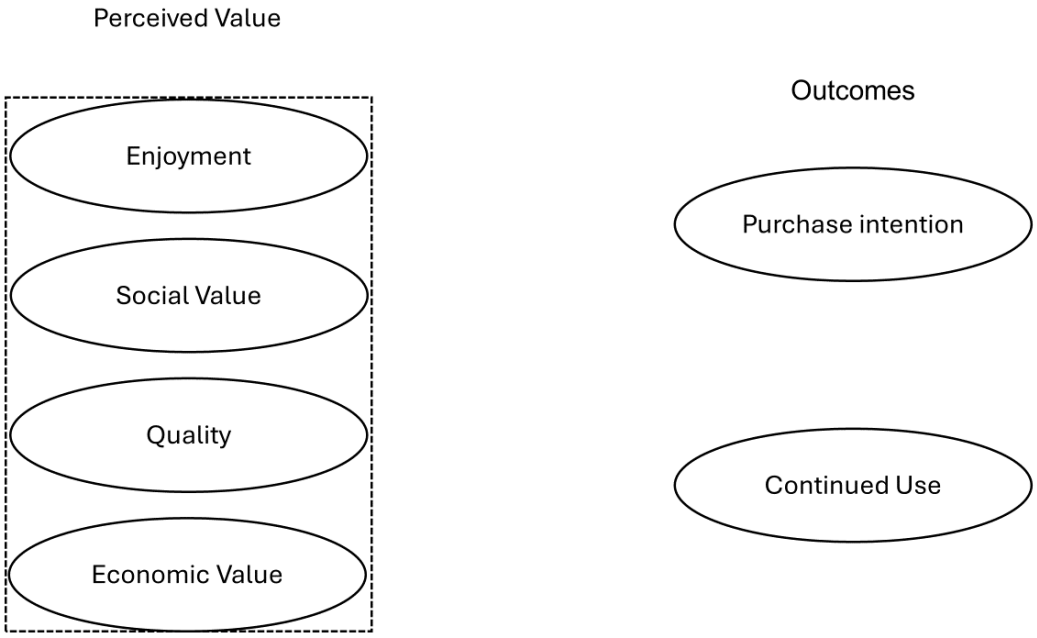

Figure 2: Conceptual model based on the research model created by Hamari, Hanner, and Koivisto's (2020) for their research on the effects of perceived value on continuous use intentions and purchase intentions

Their research model is relevant to the research being conducted in this thesis to understand the dynamics of the hybrid live service model in the videogame industry as it considers multiple dimensions of perceived value, including engagement, social value, quality, and economic value. Perceived value is a multifaceted concept encompassing

various aspects of an individual's overall product evaluation. Enjoyment in relation to this research model is the pleasure derived from the gameplay experience. Social value is the benefits of social interactions and community engagement, with quality being the perceived excellence and functionality of the game. Finally, economic value is the cost-benefit analysis performed by the consumer when considering the value of a title, in-game purchases, subscriptions, or microtransactions. Collectively, these four factors form the totality of perceived value concerning video games. Purchase intentions and continued use of a good are the outcomes established in the research model chosen for the conceptual framework of this thesis. Within their study, purchase intention referred to the purchase of the good itself, with continued use being the continued use of said good. Though their study focused on freemium titles, its foundation can be applied to the larger context of this study on the emergence of hybrid live service titles.

In closing, the conceptual framework created by Hamari, Hanner, and Koivisto (2020) provides a clear foundation for analyzing the impact of the hybrid live service model on consumer behaviour in the video game industry. More specifically, by examining the dimensions of perceived value and their influence on continued use and purchase intention, this thesis will offer valuable insights into the perception of these models and their broader applicability across digital markets.

2.5 Conclusion

This literature review provided a comprehensive analysis of the current research on the evolving landscape of business models within the video game industry. Most notably, it focused on the shift from the more traditional GaaP to the growth of a hybrid full-price title that incorporates GaaS features, reflecting broader trends in digital consumption, where the value of products extends past their initial release. (Davidovici-Nora, 2013; Dubois & Weststar, 2021), Understanding these changes is crucial in analyzing their influence on consumer value perceptions.

Integrating GaaS features into full-priced titles to extend the life cycle and engagement potential of these games has been shown to generate both opportunities and challenges

for developers and publishers (Vaudour & Heinze, 2019; He, 2021). While these hybrid models can enhance consumer engagement and create consistent revenue streams, a steady balance is required to negate backlash and maintain trust from consumers (Lehtonen, Vesa, & Harviainen, 2021). The examination of monetization strategies, specifically microtransactions and season passes, echoes such a need for balance to deliver a satisfying gameplay experience (Call & Fordham, 2018; Petrovskaya & Zendle, 2021).

Analysis of consumer value perceptions is vital to understanding the hybrid model's emergence, especially in relation to its impact on purchasing behaviour and ongoing engagement. Factors such as enjoyment, social value, quality, and economic value, as seen within the conceptual framework of this thesis, play a significant role in shaping these perceptions. With the conceptual framework established in this literature review guiding the analysis, a structured approach to understanding the hybrid model's effects can occur. By examining the relationship between perceived value, purchase intentions, and continued use, this framework will help pinpoint the broader implications of this research.

3. METHODOLOGY

Primary data was collected and utilized to support the research of this thesis. The conceptual framework for this study was based on the research model developed by Hamari, Hanner, and Koivisto (2020), which explores perceived value, continued use, and purchase intentions. The design of the interview questions was specifically tailored to align with this model.

While many studies related to the topic of purchasing behaviour and purchase intentions in video games have completed quantitative data collection methods, such as surveys, it was deemed important to utilize qualitative data collection due to the consumer-specific focus of this thesis. Choosing the qualitative method allows for a greater understanding of the specific motivations of interviewee's purchasing behaviours and was subsequently seen as the preferable option for the study of this thesis (Chrysochou, 2017, Rogers et al., 2016, Hussain and Griffiths, 2009).

3.1 Data collection

Convenience sampling was conducted to contact participants for interviews, as the researcher was acquainted with each interviewee before the start of this thesis process (Taherdoost, 2016). In order to ensure their participation in the interview process, each interviewee was initially contacted through either WhatsApp or Discord platforms. For the sake of this research, it was confirmed that each participant had purchased at least one video game title within the past year through the platform Steam. This criterion was made as it shows they are actively purchasing games. Steam also has the broadest catalog of purchasable titles and provides a wide variety of games. Eight interviews were conducted to gain substantial data for analysis. Each interview was conducted through the Zoom video conferencing platform, allowing them to be recorded and transcribed for future analysis. Though interviews were not conducted in person, cameras were active throughout the discussion in order to establish a stronger connection between the interviewer and interviewee. The following table highlights the demographic selected for the purpose of the interviews.

Table 1: Demographic of the interviews

Participant	**Age**	**Gender**	**Nationality**
P1	24	Male	Finnish
P2	24	Male	Finnish
P3	25	Male	Finnish/American
P4	25	Male	Italian
P5	24	Male	Finnish/American
P6	20	Male	American
P7	27	Male	Finnish
P8	25	Male	American

A semi-structured interview was selected for the purposes of this thesis as it allowed the interviewer to open different avenues as deemed fit within the interviews. As a result, the interviewees could divulge more information within their responses, generating more

pertinent data than initially prompted by the interview questions. Furthermore, due to the nature of this research, it was deemed necessary to generate more in-depth responses due to the multifaceted exploration of the perceived value of titles. Primarily because the semi-structured approach allows the interviewee to be treated as a knowledgeable individual, providing more substantial responses than initially prompted by the developed questionnaire (Goia et al., 2012). More of a conversation around the topic of servitization within the video game industry was allowed to develop, with interviewees discussing their first-hand experiences. Altogether, the semi-structured approach granted more data on how servitization affected video game titles' perceived value.

3.2 Interview structure

The interview structure maintains a general progression, initially focusing on the general background of the interviewee, their name, age, preferred gender, and their relationship with the gaming industry. Such questions were deemed necessary to understand the context of the participant's gaming experience and to create a comfortable atmosphere at the beginning of the interviews. The interview then focused on discussing the interviewee's perception of the hybrid model. They focus primarily on their reactions towards additional content offerings, such as seasonal updates and microtransactions, to gauge their feelings about the evolving business models.

The interview then shifts a bit toward the impact of typical features of live service titles on how the interviewees view a title. These features include monetization and consistent maintenance through frequent updates and content releases. Such questions were asked to gauge the positive and negative perceptions of participants' interactions with full-priced titles. Furthermore, these questions about updates and maintenance lead to the topic of the completeness of titles due to recent controversies and expectations of products that have a premium price within the gaming industry.

Finally, the remaining portions of the interview covered more general aspects of development in live service titles, such as community engagement and participants' general feedback on the implementation of the live service business model. These

questions ranged from how developers communicate with the community to how the participant wants these live service titles changed—aiming to understand better features that the participant would like to see going forward and features that should be removed entirely was deemed necessary as it gave a broader view of how such features are perceived. Altogether, these questions, guided by the semi-structured methodology chosen for this research paper, allowed the interviewer to stray away from the questions if a possible avenue appeared from the prompted questions.

3.3 Data analysis

The Gioia method (Gioia et al., 2012) was selected as the preferred data analysis method for this study. This method of analysis emphasizes a systematic and structured process for data collection and analysis. The coding process associated with this method involves 1st order analysis, 2nd order themes, and the creation of aggregated dimensions that captures the core insights from the interviews. 1st order analysis remains true to participants own terms and perspectives highlighting commonalities between them, followed by 2nd order analysis, highlighting common patterns and relationships tying them to frameworks to interpret the data. Finally, these themes are distilled into overarching aggregated dimensions which provide clear insights for the study conducted.

After the completion of the interviews, each session's recording was meticulously transcribed and interpreted, with commonalities being extrapolated from the responses given by interviewees. Four aggregated dimensions were formed from the commonalities of the responses representing different aspects of the interviewee's responses. The theoretical constructs that were formed bring more significant insights into the effects of the hybrid live service model on the perceived value of titles. The coding scheme that was created from the interviews is presented in Table 2 below.

Table 2: Code scheme derived from interview responses

First order Concepts	Second order concepts	Aggregated dimensions
- Plays daily or multiple times a week - Gameplay quality and features - Influenced by popularity and social influence	- Gaming Frequency and preferences - Factors influencing Game interest	- Gaming behaviour and preferences
- Generally avoids additional content if paid for title - Importance of fair pricing and value - Mixed experiences from various titles	- GaaS in full priced games - Value and perception of GaaS features	- Perceptions of Live service Features
- Significant impact on continued interest - Disengagement due to lack of updates - Transparency in communication with a community	- Factors influencing game interest - Continuous development in sustained engagement	- Drivers of engagement and loyalty
- Gameplay enhancement and respect for developers - Importance of fair pricing and value - Hesitant if content feels non-essential or overpriced	- Motivation for purchases of additional content - Value perception and fairness of GaaS features	- Purchase Behaviour

The four dimensions that appeared during the transcription and subsequent analysis of the interviews were gaming behaviour and preferences, perceptions of live service features, drivers of engagement and loyalty, and purchase behaviour. Following the appearance of these themes, they were compared to previous literature collected during the literature review section of this thesis. The comparison of collected data with research that has already been completed allows for similarities and differences about how the new hybrid model has influenced the perceived value of consumers to be distinguished. Subsequently, the origin of these similarities and differences were further analyzed, thus completing the data analysis section of this thesis.

3.4 Research Ethics

The research ethics established by Aalto University were meticulously adhered to throughout the thesis process. To ensure these standards were upheld, all participants were fully informed of their involvement in the study and consented to use their interview data. Each participant was guaranteed total anonymity and was offered the option to withdraw from the study at any time. Additionally, the research was conducted strictly with Aalto University's Code of Conduct. Proper citation practices were employed to ensure that all sources of research and studies utilized in this thesis were credited. As the author of this thesis, I assume responsibility for the retrieval of relevant research and for maintaining the ethical standards set by the university and research community.

3.5 Conclusion

This concludes the methodology section of this thesis. Firstly, literature was collected to formulate the framework of this thesis, followed by semi structured interviews for data collection. Hamari, Hanner, and Koivisto's (2020) research model was used due to their research on the perceived value of in-game content. Their model aided in the formation of questions used in the qualitative approach chosen for this research. Furthermore, semi-structured interviews were chosen to gain more data than initially prompted by the interviewees and were deemed more beneficial to understanding consumer motivations than a more quantitative approach. The interview participants were chosen through convenience sampling, as each participant was known prior to the interview and was

chosen due to their experience with the research topic. The pre-established connection between both the interviewer and the interviewee allowed for each interview to be held through the online conferencing platform Zoom, as it was deemed more convenient for participants compared to in-person interviews. Altogether, eight interviews were conducted with all participants being between the ages of 20-27, male, with ranging nationalities.

The interviews consisted of 21 questions, some with additional sub-questions, and covered various topics concerning the hybrid live service model being researched. Initially, the questions collected general information about the interviewees and their overall preferences and experiences with video games. The interview then shifted more toward their perceptions of live service features in games with an initial premium price. These questions covered standard features such as additional in game purchases and frequent updates towards the title. Following these questions, it shifted to a broader view of how participants felt about the trend of live service titles and the features and practices commonly implemented within them. Following the interviews, each session was transcribed and coded following the Gioia method of qualitative analysis, where first-order and second-order concepts were found through commonalities in responses and then narrowed down towards more specific aggregated dimensions. All of these were completed thoroughly following Aalto University research ethics.

4. Findings

The conceptual framework for the purpose of this thesis was based on the research model of Hamari, Hanner, and Koivisto's (2020) research on purchase motivations for premium content in free-to-play games. Their research model outlined Perceived Value and the underlying factors influencing a product's specific outcomes of continuous use and purchase intentions. Enjoyment, social value, quality, and economic value were highlighted as the factors that create the overarching foundation of perceived value within this medium. Within the context of the research being conducted, enjoyment is the perceived enjoyment of the offerings within a title, such as the available content and features within its offerings. As video games are interactable mediums for entertainment, the enjoyment of a product plays a vital role in a consumer's perceived value.

Additionally, with the popularity of multiplayer titles, social value plays a vital role in how various titles create value, with many consumers enjoying the ability to interact with friends. The quality of a title plays a crucial role in its influence on both outcomes, as a title that does not meet the standards expected from a consumer will neither purchase nor continue to use the specific title. Finally, economic value refers to the financial analysis completed by the consumer in relation to every aspect of the content offerings within a title.

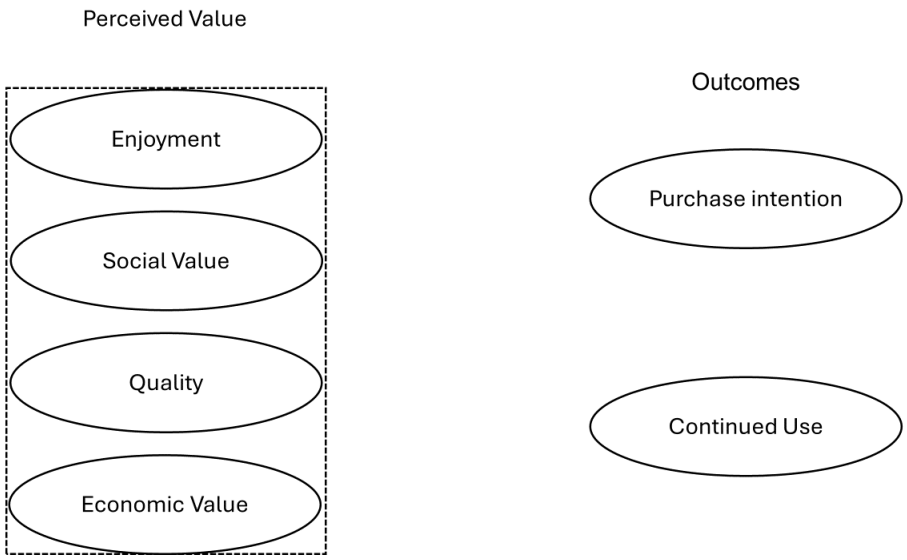

Figure 3: incomplete visualization based on Hamari, Hanner, and Koivisto's (2020) research

Figure 3 above highlights the visualization of the findings, which will evolve as the findings are discussed in further detail. More specifically, solid lines will distinguish positive correlations from respondents with dotted representing negative sentiments. The first and second-order concepts that form the larger thematic dimensions and their subsequent influence on purchase intention and continued use will be displayed accordingly. In many cases, multiple factors within perceived value played roles in both purchase intention and continued use. Therefore, the findings section will discuss each dimension separately,

culminating in a completed and concise presentation of the overarching findings from the data collected.

4.1 Gaming Behaviour and Preferences

Eight participants were chosen for the purposes of this study, all of whom have a pre-established history with the video game industry. This was found through the initial questions developed for the interview, gauging the participant's relationship with video games and their personal experiences. All eight participants highlighted a long career playing video games from an early age.

> “I would say I started playing games when I was like, 10. So I guess like, 14 years now. That's a long time.” – Paticipant 5

> “Realistically, since I was around four years old, maybe, so around 23 years now” – participant 7

> “Since I was 4 or 5 I would say. My dad got me a PlayStation 2 for Christmas and it was the first thing I played.” – Participant 8

Their responses show that all participants have more than 10 years of experience in the video game industry. Each participant, with their extensive experience in gaming, brought a wealth of knowledge to our discussion on the evolution of gaming business models. Their familiarity with the medium from a consumer standpoint was evident, having spent years playing games. They also shared their gaming habits, which revealed a common trend of playing multiple times a week or even daily. However, their genre preferences varied, with some favoring multiplayer games and others single-player games.

> “I mean, I used to play, like, every single day. Nowadays, I don't have as much time, but I play many times a week. The types of games I play, I play a lot of first person shooters, multiplayer only games, but then I also play a lot of grand strategy single player games. I do play those single player story games every now and then,

> like Bethesda, fallout, stuff like this. When a new game comes out essentially that I am interested in, but I usually play with friends." – Participant 1

Participant 1 noted specifically their diverse preference for titles that range from more action-focused first-person shooters and grand strategy games to in-depth role-playing games such as Bethesda Studios' Fallout series. While it is interesting to observe that they stated that they buy new games they are interested in, they usually play with friends.

> "I'd say I play games just about every day. And I play all kinds of strategy games, single player games, Co Op games, I usually don't play games where you play against other players." – Participant 3

Participant 3 has a similar habit in terms of daily play time as well as the same genres as preferred by participant 1. Most notably though they also stated a preference for Co Op games. This being an abbreviation for cooperative games which have a focus on playing with friends aiding each other in completing a goal.

> "I play games pretty much daily. It's been a bit less now that now that I've been busy, but pretty much daily whenever I have time, and I would say I mostly play like first person shooters. I do, like, real time strategy as well. And bit of like, sandbox games, if they're multiplayer, but I would say mostly first-person shooters are my thing." – Participant 5

Participant 5 echoed the responses of Participants 1 and 3, though most notably a preference for games that have multiplayer. Moreover, each participant highlighted varying genre preferences concerning what types of games they prefer to spend their time on; there was a general throughline regarding playing with friends. Furthermore, there was a common trend of FPS or first-person shooter games. However, participants displayed a diverse variety in terms of the genre they prefer. Participants gave similar answers when asked about factors that influenced their interest in titles, focusing on cooperation with friends and a fun experience overall.

> “That it's like a fun game and especially if it's a fun game with friends because I usually play with friends. So there's a lot of games that are not so fun alone but are with friends.” – Participant 1

Participant 1 reinforced their preference for playing with friends in titles, though they did state that the game itself must be entertaining to begin with. More interestingly, there are many titles that are only fun once there is that additional level of interaction with friends.

> “I think usually, how my gaming kind of goes is what the majority is playing. So, if the majority is playing a new popular game, then I'm usually also playing it. But then I also enjoy every now and then doing like, more like single player games, something like cyberpunk, or I don't know something dark souls.’ - Participant 2

Participant 2 highlighted that their habits of playing games generally lean towards what the majority are playing. While the social aspect was seen as a driver for their gaming behaviour, they also highlighted that they play more single-player-focused titles, such as *Cyber Punk 2077* by CD Projekt Red and *Dark Souls* by From Software.

> “That's got to be gameplay, of course. I mean, every game can have a good story can have a great theme, but if the gameplay isn't good, then no one's going to play it.” – Participant 3

Finally, Participant 3 saw that the title's core gameplay needs to be enjoyable, as no one will play the title if the core experience is not enjoyable. In the end, common themes in terms of the genre of a title varied depending on the participant. However, multiplayer or cooperative games that friends were also playing were shown by all respondents to have an impact on the enjoyment of a title. Later in the interviews, updates were brought up, as they have become commonplace within the industry. Each participant favored free content and quality-of-life updates to titles, as they found the content and fixes to be

beneficial in keeping their interest before and after release. Updates also played a more significant role in engagement and loyalty, which will be discussed later in these findings.

> “Definitely keeps me, keeps me playing the game. I'll say that. So like, if the goal for the developer is to keep like an ongoing kind of player base, I think updates like that are definitely good. Because like, if I keep playing the same game, and nothing, no updates, and I've already went through all the content, I'm not really going to continue playing it repeatedly, I need like something, something new, something fresh, so that definitely does the trick.” – Participant 2

Participant 2 brought to attention the fact that if they are to keep playing a game, they need something to get them engaged and continue to enjoy a title. Updates were seen as a reason to return as they brought something refreshing to what was deemed a dull experience after all of the content was experienced.

> “Yeah, so usually, these games have a fairly simple gameplay loop, so you're kind of doing the same thing over and over, whether it's in an arena shooter or some similar game. So, I mean, personally, I struggle to stick with games for more than a few weeks at a time, I'm always rotating. Update cadence at least, is very important to me if I want to stay on a game. So for example, we play Helldivers where they try to have a fairly major update every month. And with my attention span, you know, I may take a week, maybe two week break between updates, but then you're always coming back.” – Participant 3

Participant 3 specifically brought attention to the gameplay loop of live service titles and the simple loop they have. They called attention to the fact that these updates are a reason to return to titles that become repetitive. They, as well as other Participants, brought attention to the title *Helldivers 2* by Arrowhead Studios, which has a major update once a month. Most notably, while they take breaks from the title once the content gets old, they return with the release of a major update.

> “If I know that a certain game won't have future updates, or DLCs, it kind of lowers my motivation to get into the game in the first place. Because I know that the content will be over sooner than later, or like, rather quickly. If I know that the game is or the publishers are known to pump out DLCs, and additional content it motivates me to get into the game more in depth, because I know that there's going to be more content later on that I can play through.” – Participant 7

Participant 7 echoed the same sentiments as other participants. However, they specifically noted that if they do not see the game promising additional content or updates, it prevents them from making a purchase in the first place. This expectation from Participant 7 highlights a shift in consumer mindset, where regular content updates are seen as a crucial part of gaming rather than a sign of an unfinished product at launch. Throughout the initial discussion in relation to gaming behaviour and interests, a common theme was that if a game was perceived as enjoyable, each participant would make the initial purchase, as visualized below (Figure 4).

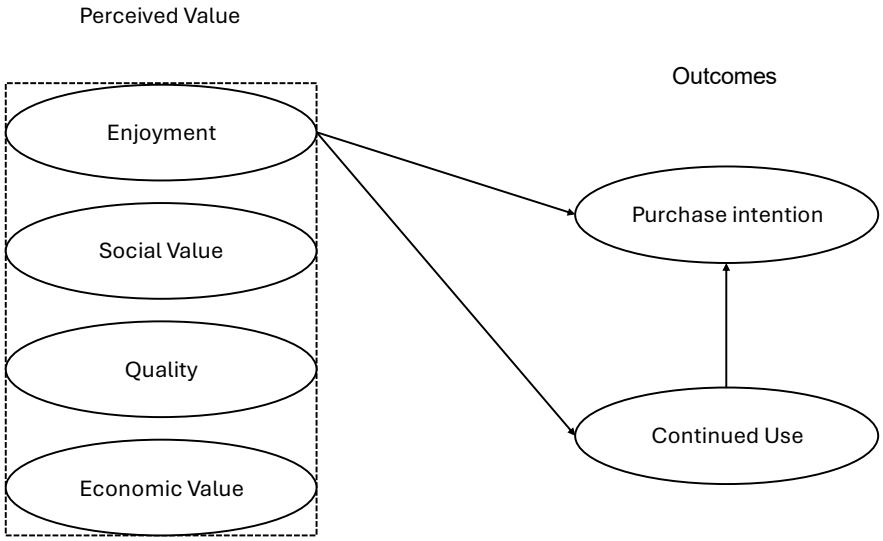

Figure 3: Findings of Gaming Behaviour and interest and its effect on Purchase intentions and Continued use

Gaming frequency and factors influencing interest, the second-order concepts of this aggregated dimension, were found to primarily impact enjoyment and social value in relation to the perceived value of a title. While the social value of titles, particularly interactions with friends, emerged as a significant factor in their continued use of a product, there was a strong emphasis from participants on its influence on enjoyment. While many participants noted cooperation and interaction with friends as important aspects of their gaming Behaviour, participants presented enjoyment as more influential in making the initial purchase. Regarding how live service titles directly affect perceived value drivers, Participant 3 gave an interesting insight. More specifically, that gameplay was the primary driver for their interest in titles overall. However, they noted that such live service titles have a generic gameplay loop, requiring additional free content updates to remain engaging.

4.2 Perception of live service features

After establishing participants' relationships with video games, the interviews shifted towards the perception of live service tiles and the features that were explicitly seen within them. Participants highlighted various aspects of full-priced live service titles, with positive and negative experiences highlighted throughout this new model's emergence. These perceptions are important as the model begins to become more prevalent within the industry, more specifically with how it affects the perception of quality and economic value concerning consumers' perceived value. Participants consistently noted the continuous content as maintaining engagement and enhancing the overall quality of a game. However, there were significant concerns about the economic implications of additional costs, seen with microtransactions, especially when these were added on top of an already substantial initial purchase price. The interviews reveal the importance of fair pricing for additional content and the need to balance the implementation of monetization strategies. In terms of each participant's experience with live service titles, each mentioned having paid for full-price titles with service features and varying reactions toward them.

> “I feel like it's changed throughout the years. I used to play a lot of *Call of Duty* when I was younger. Until *Modern Warfare 3*, pretty much the only way you could unlock skins and progress in the game was just by playing the game… But in Advanced Warfare, they introduced loot boxes thing and that's kind of like the first introduction I had to this sort of stuff. … My reaction usually is not so nice because it's, you're already paying full price for the game and if the main way that you get cool things in the game is by loot boxes or things that you kind of need to pay real money for. I think there's a problem.” – Participant 1

Participant 1 called attention to the *Call of Duty* franchise by Activision/Blizzard and, specifically, the early introduction of loot boxes. Loot boxes are items players can purchase which offer a selection of cosmetic items at random with varying levels of rarity. More specifically, noting how players were essentially gambling for features previously offered for free with the initial purchase of a title. Elaborating further, the high initial cost with such a focus on monetization negatively impacts their perception of a title.

> “I see what you can get. I want to say for free, it's not for free, because you're already buying the game for 40 to 60 euros sometimes, in some cases, even 70. So whether my reaction is of course to see kind of what can you get for the base game... So extra payments to unlock new content, then it can be frustrating, of course, but then it really depends on the methods and how you can gain other things for what you've already paid.” – Participant 3

Participant 3 echoed Participant 1's sentiments, discussing how they appraise titles for what is given for the initial asking price without the need for purchasing additional in-game content. However, they noted that the methods to unlock additional content could be frustrating if not implemented correctly, especially in a title that they have already purchased. Participant 3's notion of implementation methods calls attention to the need to balance how such features are implemented within a title under the hybrid live service model.

> “I think it really depends. I think if a game that you pay full price for is kind of forcing you to pay more money, for example, to boost [progression] or get items that are really overpowered, I think that's pretty stupid. But I think Helldivers does it well, where there's these battle passes that never go away, so you can get them whenever you want, and you know, nothing actually impacts the gameplay itself… So yeah, I would say, it really depends on how they do it. If it's blatant that they're just trying to get as much money out of you as possible, then of course, I'm turned off by it.” – Participant 5

Participant 5 elaborated further about their reactions, with negative experiences with titles that focused on monetization compared to providing sufficient offerings for the initial purchase. Participant 5 called attention to the 2024 title *Helldivers 2* as a good example of live service implementation by not limiting the offerings through timed content and offering offerings that do not provide additional benefits to remain competitive. Overall, the participants saw that a balance was required in implementing live service titles, especially with a heavy initial purchase, as they expect value for the money they spend. While participants noted positive experiences, such as with *Helldivers 2*, they did say that their evaluation of offerings has been negative with implementing features. Microtransactions and seasonal updates, which provide additional content between larger updates, were further discussed with participants.

> “it's kind of like if you bought *Europa Universalis 4* without DLC, it's almost unplayable. Yeah. It's missing core features that you must pay real money for in DLC form to actually fix. And nowadays the game if you want the actual current form of the game, which I do have, it's hundreds of euros. It's a lot of money for that and it's kind of nice that they keep updating it, so I do appreciate it because I really like the game. However, there's like a limit to it. At least the base game needs to be playable.” – Participant 1

Participant 1 called attention to the title *Europa Universalis 4*; while having spent a substantial amount of money on the title's DLC, they expressed frustration that they had

to spend it to fully enjoy the title's offerings. Conflicted feelings were expressed as they do enjoy the game but that the initial purchasing price essentially offered an unfinished game until those additional purchases were made. It is interesting to note that the game's overall quality is good; however, the economic value did not equate to the experience they invested in.

> “For example, if I think of like [Destiny 2], I think that's a good example of a game that can get pretty boring, pretty stale, unless they have those updates, except their updates, of course cost but like, I think it's definitely good to keep it up to date, because otherwise you're not really going to retain your player base.” – Participant 3

> “I feel like most of the time with something for example [Destiny 2], it's merely a money grab the fact that they introduce new stuff, however, they locked it behind the [10-20 euro] paywall. And when they do that, it's either you have to pay that amount of money, or you have to go through a very rigorous and annoying process to get those same rewards. Oftentimes, within the paid tracks, they will offer only exclusive rewards. So it kind of becomes frustrating when all the company does is put out live service updates, and then lots of things behind microtransactions.”
> – Participant 6

Participants 3 and 6 called attention to the title Destiny 2, a full-priced game that shifted towards a free-to-play GaaS model with paid expansions. More specifically, the fact that content is generally locked behind an additional paywall, limiting features behind additional content, to enjoy the game fully. Participant 6 explicitly mentioned that the paid track offers additional exclusive rewards, with a rigorous process to unlock content without that additional payment. While Participant 3 noted that the updates are beneficial as it helps to retain the player base, participant 6 clearly highlights the issues that can arise from limiting the core experience behind additional payments.

> “I think seasonal updates are honestly pretty good for the health of a game just to keep things from stagnating. I'll be it that can get abused regards to a lot of modern day video game development, as like you can see with more [major] titles, but I don't see a problem with it, If it's done well. That's just the biggest thing, though, is it has to be done well. Otherwise, it kind of goes in the same boat for me where when they're asking 10 bucks for an armor skin on a game that's only been out for a week, it just kind of kind of irritates me a little bit.” – Participant 8

Participant 8's insight into seasonal updates reflects the broader theme of the necessity for balance. Although updates are beneficial for preventing stagnation, they must be implemented thoughtfully to avoid negative perceptions of economic value and quality.

Quality and economic value emerged as themes in participants in participants perception of GaaS features in full priced titles. The analysis of interviews clearly highlighted that these drivers significantly influenced their interest in purchasing and the ongoing engagement with titles. Participants' direct experiences with monetization strategies, such as microtransactions and additional purchasable content, varied widely. Though these experiences often led to negative perceptions of the economic value of titles with the high initial price of titles, seasonal updates were viewed as beneficial with enhancements to

quality and engagement. Their influences in relation to the outcomes of purchase intention and continued use can be seen in Figure 5 below.

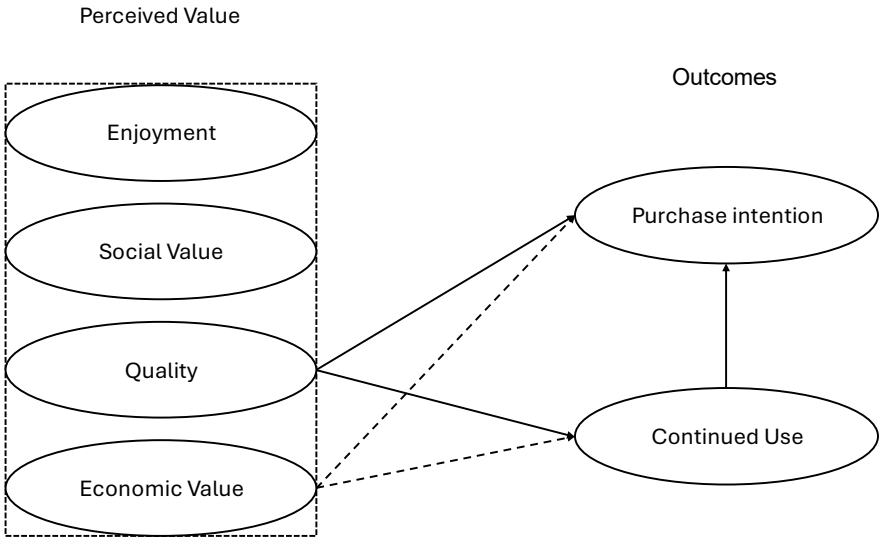

Figure 4: Findings of Perception of live service features visualized.

Aspects in terms of monetization with microtransactions and seasonal updates created differing reactions. More specifically, microtransactions and additional purchasable content negatively affected the economic value of titles for participants, primarily due to the substantial initial purchase required to play. Seasonal updates, however, were seen as having a positive impact on the overall quality of a game, which echoed responses in the previous section of these findings. Breathing life into a title and boosting continued use were considered beneficial as you gain more for free for the premium purchase of a title. Though, as Participant 1 mentioned with *Europa Versalis 4,* the implementation of which can be seen as predatory. Other participants echoed these sentiments, seeing additional content locked behind a paywall. These findings call attention to the fact that seasonal updates positively affect quality, which in turn influences continued use. Additional content needs to be priced fairly, as it can deter consumers from making the additional purchase and returning to a title as the price to enter said additional content is not deemed as worthwhile. As these offerings are integral aspects of live service titles, their discussion was vital for the purpose of this research on perceived value.

Overall, while seasonal updates were recognized for their positive impact on quality and continued use, the approach taken by many developers through monetization through additional content needs to be reconsidered. Fair pricing is crucial to maintaining a positive perception of the game's economic value, which, as expressed by Participants, has been negatively impacted through predatory implementation. These insights emphasize the importance of thoughtful implementation of live service features to enhance perceived value and maintain player satisfaction concerning quality and economic value.

4.3 Drivers of engagement and loyalty

Drivers of engagement and loyalty drifted focus away from seasonal updates, small patches between more significant updates, and focused on more extensive updates within hybrid live service titles. These updates can overhaul the entirety of a game's features and are often released for free. How these updates affect perceptions of titles and developers is an aspect of perceived value that needs to be considered. The driver of quality presented mixed in terms of the outcomes of purchase intention and continued use from participants, but more surprisingly social value played a large role both positively and negatively as well. However, instead of interactions with other players, discourse in terms of developers' communication appeared throughout the interviews. Updates were heavily discussed by participants with similar attitudes towards these more extensive updates, as seen with more minor seasonal updates.

> "The initial reaction is always a bit skeptical because it tends to mean that they release a base game that doesn't feel like it's complete, as in a way it feels like they're selling an early access game and then kind of continuing to develop it over the years and selling you the extra parts. But it's very case by case basis, you kind of have to see once the game releases what kind of state is it in. And then do you like it enough to continue to buy into that life service." – Participant 3

Participant 3 highlighted a feeling of skepticism with the fact that many of the titles that come with the promise of continuous updates tend to be unfinished. Moreover, they receive early access to the game, with developers selling additional parts later. Focusing on the initial release, Participant 1 specifically mentioning at release evaluating the state of the product before making that initial purchase into the live service in order to ensure a standard of completeness with the title.

> "I mean, it's nice, especially if you pay the 60 euros for that, because if people want it, they have updates, they will talk with their friends about the update, and some friends that haven't bought the game yet will probably buy it in the future." – Participant 4

Participant 4 saw the benefit of larger updates in a more social view more precisely generating additional interest in titles, as a dialogue between players and their friends can lead to more interaction with a title. Their comment specifically showcases how updates can encourage word-of-mouth promotion, demonstrating its effect on driving engagement and loyalty towards a title in the long term.

> "I'm all for it. That's what I think should be there. I do believe that developers have some sort of responsibility on up keeping the game and also providing additional content to some extent, but of course, they also have the right to ask for money if they want for the content, because I understand it costs money. So yeah, goes a little bit of both ways." – Participant 7

Participant 7 more directly states it's the job of the developer to provide these larger content updates as well as provide maintenance for a title post-launch. Though they do realize the financial burden ongoing development entails and admit they have the right to ask for additional money for said content. This does echo similar sentiments from the previous section, as the additional content was seen to benefit quality, though a balance was required in terms of monetization of said content.

> "I think if they come out the gate saying that they're going to be introducing new content from square one, especially if it's only a couple of weeks after the game launches, it kind of gives me a bad feeling about the game's future, considering that just means the content they're offering was more than likely already available, like it was already made, and they're just drip feeding it to you." – Participant 8

This quote directly underscores the skepticism seen in Participant 3's response in relation to already completed content being repackaged for later sales. Similar sentiments were given in general discourse about the perception of titles, highlighting the potential harm to trust and loyalty of additional content. All Participants found that the state of many titles released today were considered incomplete. More specifically, many titles released by major developers seem rushed or unfinished. Additionally, some participants stated how unfinished titles have changed their views on titles, developers, and publishers.

> “It certainly brings a feeling that the developer or publisher, most likely the publisher kind of doesn't care about the quality of the game, they just settling something to make money. I mean, life service games in general, kind of give me that vibe. They're not. They're not doing it because this is like the new way for passionate developers to keep making their games, they're doing it because it's the most profitable way if you succeed.” – Participant 3

Participant 3 clearly displayed that many live service titles, but more specifically unfinished titles, give the impression that the developer or publisher does not care about the quality of a game. Going into more detail, such aspects make the game feel as though it is simply a vehicle to make more money rather than release a fun experience to consumers.

> “Since I was a little bit disappointed, it kind of made me realize, I don't want to necessarily preorder any games anymore. I want to wait and see what people say. I'm a bit more skeptical now, especially since the games prices have increased so much. You'll see new [major releases] costing almost 100 euros, and I think that

> that's pretty ridiculous. It's a lot of money for a game, so It definitely makes me a little skeptical now." – Participant 5

In terms of how this common trend of unfinished products being released has impacted purchase intentions, Participant 5 stated that they no longer preorder games, especially because of the increasing price of titles being released. Their skepticism comes from a certain expectation of quality in relation to the premium cost of the title. Overall, this leads them to not commit financially due to lowered trust in the quality of titles.

> "If I see a big publisher brand on the game, I usually give it the side eye for a while and wait, like about a month after release, just to actually see what reviewers and people are saying about it. Whereas if it's like a small indie team, and I see the game, it looks pretty interesting. If It's like 20 bucks I'll just throw it down and give it a try, because why not? I tend to be attracted towards smaller indie dev teams than these big super corporations." – Participant 8

Participant 8 had sentiments similar to those of Participant 5 in relation to larger games, specifically highlighting a trust gap between larger developers and indie developers. Their tendency to wait for community feedback before purchasing titles from larger publishers indicates a preference for the perceived passion and quality of smaller indie teams.

> "I expect them to fix it for free. That's one important aspect of it, I don't want them to release an incomplete game, and then tell us that, oh, you can buy this DLC that cost 20 euros and you get the rest of the game. That's not kind of, I guess that goes back to the transparency issue of the pricing that you pay for something that you expect to get, and then you only get half of it. So it's not really fair. And I expect them to release a full game as fast as possible. For free, of course, without compromising the quality of the game. I am not going to pay for that." – Participant 7

Participant 7's response underscores the expectation to provide a complete experience after the fact as a debt to those who purchased the title. Overall, participants found that there was a change in how they perceived titles and their purchasing behaviour because many releases tend to be perceived as low quality due to the game being unfinished, affecting their view on the quality of these types of releases. The discussion on these continuous updates continued in relation to changes they would like to see within the industry. Responses varied, but there was a common theme seen with participants, more specifically, the fact that there was transparency throughout the development process of the title at release.

> “I think a lot of them do it nowadays, which is good, but very much establishing beforehand the DLC policy and sticking to it. Mhm. Saying that, uh, hey, first DLC will be in half a year, it'll be something like this. Then we'll have one every year or something and it'll be, it will cost as much in like just sort of a roadmap. So you know what you're getting yourself into.” – Participant 1

This quote from Participant 1 emphasizes the importance of transparency for developers in establishing and adhering to a clear policy for additional content. The distinction of a roadmap allows players to know what to expect from the title regarding updates and additional content releases, in turn generating a positive influence on the continued use of a product.

> “Transparency I think is very important. If you're a live service game, and you keep updating it, I think it would be very good to know that beforehand, and before I make the decision to buy this game. I want to know what's the kind roadmap of sorts. Then I know kind of what to expect, or that at least I know that there's going to be regular updates like that… then if you're not expecting new content, you know that's what you signed up for, but if you are, then you know that that's coming. Obviously, it's going to impact your decision to buy that game or not.” – Participant 2

> “A road map would be ideal, in my opinion about like, if you say like one month, okay, we're going to do this update in June, and I don't know, in August, and then September, we're going to have 20 more characters, for example. In that case, it's nice. And if they also deliver on time, if you have a roadmap, it's very nice, and you can get excited about the game.” – Participant 4

Mirroring Participant 1's stance on transparency, Participant 2 established the significance of communication in the decision to purchase a title if there is a clear understanding of the schedule the developer intends to have with the project, which impacts engagement and loyalty to a title. Similarly, Participant 4 noted how excitement is generated for titles with clear communication with the community and their plans for the year ahead.

> “I really hope to see more transparency with the communication of these game developers. For example, if they set a launch date, but for some reason, they can't maybe launch a full game on that date, I would much rather see them say, hey, sorry, we have to push this back a little bit, rather than just release an unfinished game. Because that's just going to ruin their reputation and make them look bad and it's going to make me less inclined to even buy the game eventually, even if they might fix everything.” – Participant 5

Returning to the topic of unfinished titles, participant 5 discussed communication and its importance in the release of a title. Delays are commonplace for the development of titles, and Participant 5 wishes for titles to get the development needed, further emphasizing how communication can directly affect long-term engagement and loyalty. In regard to full-priced live service titles, respondents gave contradictory responses in terms of their view of updates compared to the discussion of live service features. However, the reasoning behind these contradictory statements was not because the updates themselves were negative, but the reason for said updates was due to the perception of titles' unfinished quality. Furthermore, Participants highlighted the need for transparency in the development and upkeep of titles. More specifically, they view transparency

positively when communication with the community is given. These findings are represented in Figure 6 below.

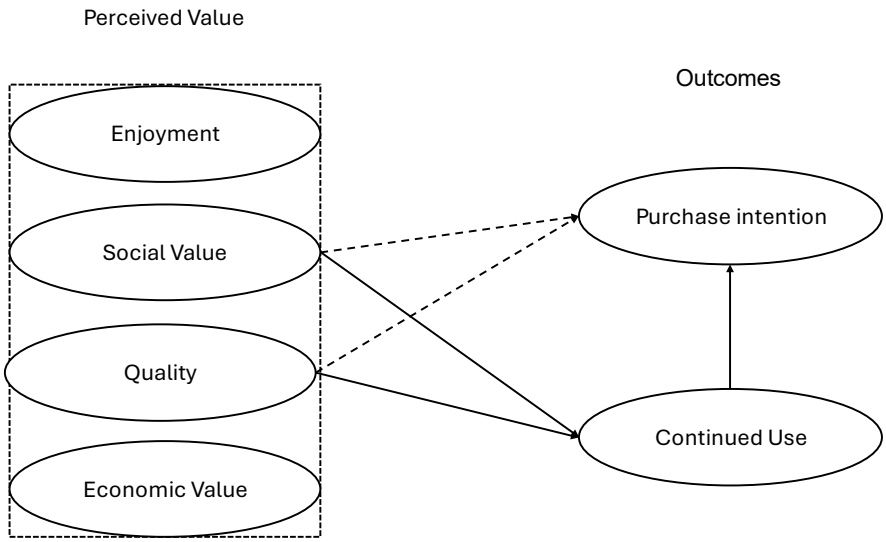

Figure 5: Enjoyment and loyalty visualized within the conceptual framework

Even though participants felt that the more extensive updates tended to be in response to significant issues concerning full-priced live service titles, many of them mentioned that the maintenance of the titles encouraged them to return to see how the changes affected gameplay. However, the notion that many titles felt unfinished presented an opposing view on quality and, in turn, negatively influenced their purchase intentions of titles. Participants 5 and 8 clearly mentioned they tend to wait till after release to see how well the community receives them. As seen in Figure 6 above, the impact of quality parallels that of social value. The importance of communication and transparency from developers emerged as a surprising yet critical theme from the interviews. Transparent communication significantly enhances social value by fostering a sense of trust and community among players. When developers are open about their plans and progress, players feel more connected and valued, which boosts their engagement and loyalty. These findings underpin the importance of developer transparency in maintaining positive relationships with the gaming community, reinforcing the broader implications of this study on perceived value in the video game industry.

4.4 Purchase Behaviour

Purchase behaviour is the final dimension seen through the interviews. While microtransactions were discussed in the perception of live service features, this dimension was seen to look further into the core offerings of the microtransactions seen within full-priced live service titles and the motivations behind their purchase. As they are commonplace in free-to-play and full-priced titles, analyzing their perception within these new hybrid models is essential. A common trend concerning quality and economic value was found in participant's responses. An overall negative influence was given through responses from participants for both purchase intentions and continued use intentions. However, in relation to quality, it was deemed as overall positive in terms of purchase intentions. Participants expressed varying motivations for and against making additional purchases for titles they have played.

> “I watch a lot of YouTube videos and follow a lot of creators. When I see them playing with all the new stuff and showing strategies with all the new things, and then I try to do it myself and I realise I'm like, “oh no, I'm missing a DLC. I can't even do this cool thing”. That kind of incentivizes me to buy the DLC. It may be in this more negative way because I'm not so happy about it.” – Participant 1

This quote from Participant 1 illustrates how external factors influenced their motivations for purchasing content, primarily due to the wanting to replicate strategies scene online. Though this was for features that were locked behind a paywall of additional downloadable content and offered some sort of additional functionality instead of cosmetic alterations.

> “For example, with Rainbow Six Siege, that was a game that cost money, and they have the added Battle Pass as well. So, I guess if I'm gonna play it a lot, I'm more drawn into buying the Battle Pass. But if I think about it, and I'm like, ‘Okay, I'm not really going to play this game a lot’, then I probably won't buy anything else.” – Participant 5

Battle Passes are a season pass that allows players limited access to cosmetic unlocks for further customization within titles. As it is a focal point in the progression of many GaaS titles, Participant 5's distinction about enjoying the quality of a title and its influences on such a content purchase. In particular, their avoidance of making the next purchase due to a lack of commitment to the title.

> "The motivation for the purchase is often to keep up with the game. Normally, they will have some sort of incentive or other people will buy it, so then I will in turn have to get it." – Participant 6

The above quote highlights the fact that many titles have some incentive for people to participate in such purchases, influencing participants to remain competitive with the rest of the community in general. These responses from Participants called attention to the fact that the content they purchased allowed them to play additional content that expanded the game's initial offerings compared to purely cosmetic offerings, which are commonplace in many paid and free-to-play live service titles. Many participants criticized implementing this, specifically concerning microtransactions within these full-priced titles.

> "I'm not a huge fan of the fact that when they develop games, like premium games, that don't have let's say skins or armor or whatever, that looks decent for the premium of the game that you already purchased, but then they kind of put the real developer and art developer time into the things that they sell afterwards… Stop limiting the experience that people have already paid for, like make things optional purchases on the side, but like also make content people deserve for already purchasing a full price game." – Participant 3

Limiting content behind a paywall was heavily discussed in previous sections, and similar sentiments are echoed within Participant 3's experiences with cosmetics. Specifically, limiting the offers in-game and selling better appearances through in-game stores, even though a premium initial purchase was present, again calls attention to the need for balance in monetization in order to maintain trust and satisfaction.

> “they'll have just like basic cosmetics that'll just be not worth the price of like $20. So it'd be like a few shaders, a few skins, maybe a vehicle or whatever. I definitely think that if I'm going to be paying $20 I want something that will make it worth my $20. Whether or not it'd be access to different story or like new equipment, for example, in a game like Destiny 2 where you can get through the battle pass pretty quickly. I want to see that to make my money worth it in the end.” – Participant 6

> “In regards to like live service games, more realistic pricing, I think, if you have somebody thats already spent 60 bucks on a game, and you're asking 20 bucks for some like skin pack or something benign, by no reasonable means, would anyone that doesn't have just a bunch of disposable income, would by themselves.” – Participant 8

Perceived economic value and quality is the focus of participant 6 and 8's view on microtransactions, requiring them to offer value for money and, more importantly, that it provide content outside of visual changes to their experience for a price point of 20 dollars or more. The consensus from participants being that fair pricing and more premium content offerings concerning the price of content offered are needed to make said offerings more appealing. Furthermore, Participants 3 and 6 noted that it feels as though the experience is limited when they have already purchased a title, and the experience is seemingly locked behind additional paywalls. Participant 8 discussed this further with what was deemed a predatory practice in purchasing a premium currency. These premium currencies are generally offered for purchase in order to use the in-game shop of GaaS titles, offering varied cosmetic changes for the player to implement.

> “I don't like it when games do in game currencies, essentially, you'll have currency packages where you spend $1, you get 100 credits, you spend $5, you get 500. Then they'll make bundles that will be like 350. You can't spend the amount of money that you want just to get that bundle, you have to spend more, which I feel

> is kind of predatory and it makes you spend more on the game than you want to." – Participant 8

Other participants also discussed the topic of premium currencies in a more positive light, citing their experience with some titles that allow the player to earn premium currency through gameplay.

> "And after doing the Season Pass to completion, I have enough in game currency to buy the next season pass, kind of like incentivizes you to play the game more, and you'll be rewarded. So I think I think it varies a lot." – Participant 1

> "I like the idea of being able to earn premium currency, because most of these companies they don't, they'll just ask for your money they want they have a premium currency to purchase the content. So the ability to earn premium currency, in side of the games, I think if it makes things feel a lot more fair, in a way, it gives everyone the chance to earn things." – Participant 3

Participants 1 and 3's insights suggest that incorporating mechanisms for earning premium currency can significantly enhance player satisfaction and loyalty. This not only encourages consistent engagement with the tiles but also ensures that all players, regardless of their ability to spend money, have a fair opportunity to access premium content. Aligning with the broader themes of this section, highlighting the need for balance and player-friendly economic models in live service titles. Overall, purchase behaviour echoed findings in relation to perceived economic value in perceptions of GaaS features. More specifically, specifics were mentioned concerning the microtransactions of their participant's relationships with the additional offerings. How it influenced their perceived value of a title is seen in Figure 7 below.

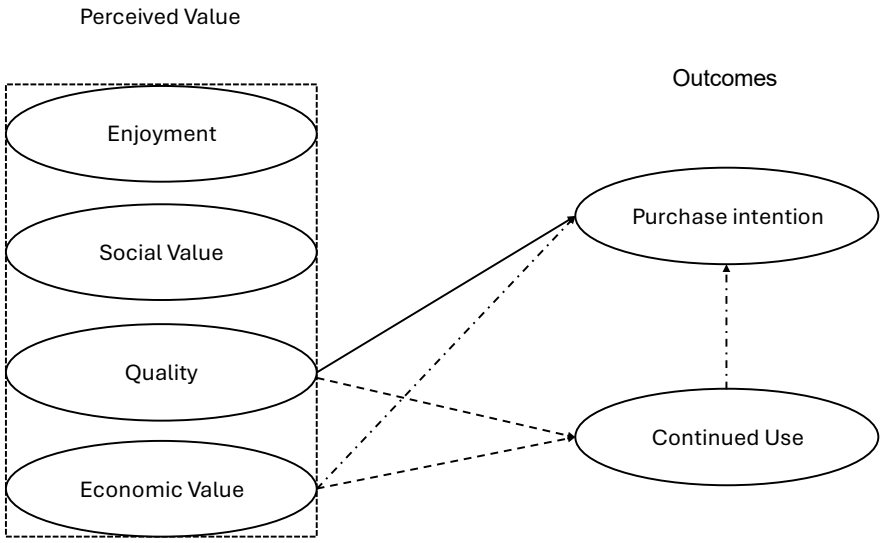

Figure 6: Purchase behaviour aggregated dimension visualized

As seen through analysis, second-order concepts of motivation for purchases of additional content, value perception, and fairness of GaaS features were prevalent throughout this aggravated dimension. Similar points were echoed in the perception of GaaS features due to overlap within features regarding the topics at hand. Overall, Participants found that the additional offerings within full-priced live service titles were only worth the value given if they added additional value to the price, as Participant 4 mentioned. Participant 4's notion of the perceived quality of the game and the additional offering influencing purchases was seen in a positive light. However, other participants noted experiences of lowered quality and value due to content being moved to additional content purchases instead of being offered in the game. Most notably, Participant 3's experience had limited offerings within its core game compared to the premium content shop.

Furthermore, the use of in-game currencies was discussed with general negativity towards their value overall, as seen with Participant 8, though with praise for what was deemed fair practices. These insights bring attention to the need for balanced strategies in terms of monetization within live service titles. Overall, the economic value of full-price live service titles negatively affected both continued use and, in turn, purchase intention because the additional purchases would limit the overall experience due to the high

valuation of the offerings. Furthermore, the need for more utility of purely cosmetic offerings further negatively affected continued use; however, purchases that provided high-quality content were seen as positive.

4.5 Synthesis of findings

The hybrid live service model and its implementation have affected consumers' perceived value and, in turn, their purchase intention and continued use of titles under this business model. The aggregated dimensions are seen through data analysis, gaming behaviour, and preferences, perceptions of GaaS features, engagement and loyalty, and purchase behaviour all influenced purchase behaviour positively and negatively. However, these dimensions tended to affect not only one but two drivers of perceived value in terms of the evaluations from participants.

Gaming behaviour and preferences are thematically connected to the drivers of enjoyment and social value; furthermore, it was seen to impact both purchase intentions and continued use in different ways. Enjoyment as a whole was seen to positively influence Participant's purchase intentions, as enjoyment of the core service seemed to supplement their preferences in terms of gameplay. More specifically, participants noted that if the game is fun, they will play it. Additionally, social value was seen through participant responses to not influence purchase intention but the enjoyment of the title. While the ability to play with friends did not directly influence a purchase of a title, it was shown to affect continued use, thereby influencing purchase intentions, as Participant 2 noted they tend to play a title that the majority of their friends are playing. One aspect discussed in relation to preferences in titles updated; though only briefly touched upon in terms of preferences, participant 3 gave an interesting insight into live service titles. Specifically, the simplicity of the core gameplay loop and the necessity of updates in order to continue enjoying a titles now stale content. Overall, the perceived enjoyment of a title was seen to positively affect purchase intentions, while perceived social value supplemented enjoyment. Moreover, while not directly influencing purchase intentions, it did positively affect the continued use of a product, which led to purchase intentions.

Perception of live service features is thematically connected to the perceived value drivers of quality and economic value, affecting purchase intentions and continued use in different ways. Quality as a whole was seen to positively impact both purchase intentions and continued use through seasonal updates offering additional content. Overall, creating additional value for offerings available within a title. However, frustration was seen from the experiences of participants in relation to how these additional offerings were given. Participants 2 and 6 specifically highlighted a duality of perceptions, with Participant 2 seeing the benefit of additional content in regard to player retention, though Participant 6 noted the predatory nature of its implementation and accessibility of said content. Led to the driver of economic value, as the substantial initial purchase with additional content requiring additional payment was deemed unnecessary. Overall, while the benefits in quality of a title were generally seen as positive, the economic burden of additional offerings seen within the business model was perceived as negative towards purchase intentions and continued use of a title.

Engagement and loyalty was the third aggregated dimension seen through data analysis and primarily focused on the larger free updates that fundamentally overhaul the experience of a game for players. Significantly influenced by both the quality of updates and the communication from developers, participants highlighted that these extensive updates impacted their perceptions of the game and developers. However, there was skepticism regards the state of games at release. Primarily, that games were incomplete and that the subsequent updates were merely fulfilling what should have initially been implemented in the title. Surprisingly, an additional factor in social value was seen during discussions on updates as communication from developers was seen as beneficial in the continued use of a title, as participants were aware of what was to come. Participant 5 stated its importance in word-of-mouth promotion between players and their friends. Overall, there was a negative effect from both quality and social value in regards to purchase intentions due to titles being perceived as unfinished, though these updates, if communicated openly with the community, were seen to positively affect the continued use of a title.

The final dimension seen through data analysis was that of Purchase behaviour, more specifically in relation to the microtransactions seen in live service titles. While Perceptions of live service features discussed their implementation, this dimension focused specifically on the value associated with them. Perceived value drivers of quality and economic value were prevalent throughout this dimension as these additional microtransactions were generally seen as not worthwhile and overpriced with a title's already premium initial price. Participant 8 was the most vocal about their disdain for unfair practices in already premium titles, especially calling attention to in-game currencies. Overall, a call for balance in how these features are implemented and the value provided was given by participants. Participant 3, in particular, calls attention to the fact that many titles seemingly lock better equipment behind the purchases, which would have been present in previous GaaP titles from the initial purchase. Negative perceptions were seen through all interviews in terms of quality and economic value, though unsurprisingly, quality was seen to positively affect purchase intention if the additional offerings were implemented in a fair way by not limiting the experience, echoing similar perceptions from the dimension of Perceptions of GaaS Features.

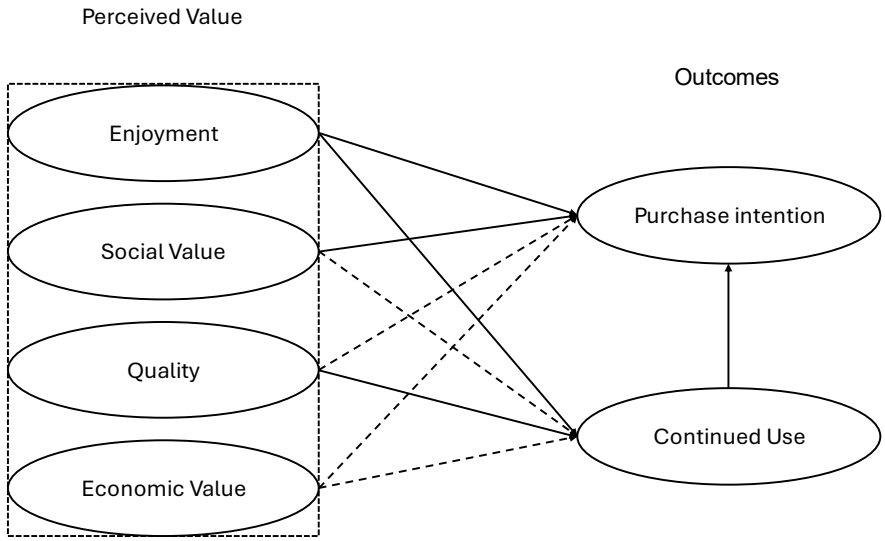

Figure 7: Synthesis of findings from aggregated dimensions applied to Hamari, Hanner, and Koivisto's (2020) research model

Altogether, the four drivers of perceived value affected both purchase intention and continued use of full-priced live service titles in various ways, as seen in Figure 8 above.

Enjoyment of the core offerings in relation to gameplay features was seen as positive enforcers of both purchase intention and continued use intentions, reinforcing that the title needs to provide an enjoyable performance that constantly adds new features. Social value was stated as a motivator for purchase intention from word-of-mouth promotion of updates and new content, as well as transparent communication from developers. However, in relation to continued use of the service, it was seen as a negative motivator. If there is no clear communication of the future of the service, players will stop playing. Quality varied drastically in terms of many aspects of full-priced live service titles. Many respondents found that the initial state of many titles was considered unfinished, though the initial status of the title would prevent making an initial purchase, the quality of the larger updates and upkeep of the title were seen in a positive light, influencing continued use later on. Finally, economic value was seen to be influenced by a myriad of factors, though ultimately negative in its totality. As these titles require a premium initial purchase, the titles being perceived as unfinished, as well as offering various additional in-game purchases, was seen to influence the value seen with these full-priced titles negatively. Preventing participants from not only purchasing the tiles but also from continuing to use a service after making a purchase.

4.6 Conclusion

The synthesis of the findings highlights that the hybrid live service models significantly impact consumer value perception, influencing both purchase intentions and continued use intentions of titles under this business model. The analyzed aggregated dimensions of gaming behaviour and preferences, perceptions of GaaS features, engagement and loyalty, and purchase behaviour make it evident that multiple dimensions interact to shape consumer attitudes towards this hybrid model.

Gaming behaviour and preferences were linked to enjoyment and social value, which are key drivers, where enjoyment positively influences purchase intentions by aligning with gameplay preferences. More importantly, if a game is fun, they are more likely to make the initial purchase. Social value, while not directly impacting purchase intentions, enhances continued use by enabling cooperation with others, thereby influencing

purchase intentions. Overall, while various genres influenced the purchases that participants made, it inevitably came down to the enjoyment of the title and its core features, further influenced by the ability to interact with friends as well.

Perceptions of live service features were connected to perceived value drivers of quality and economic value. Quality, primarily through seasonal updates, positively impacted purchase intentions and continued use. Participants appreciated minor updates in between larger updates that provided minor improvements to the overall experience, contributing to the perception of good quality. However, economic value was a divisive issue. Participants expressed clear frustration over the necessity of additional payments for content that they felt should have been included in the initial purchase. This inevitably led to negative perceptions of the game's overall value. While additional content can aid in the retention of players, predatory monetization strategies and the inaccessibility of certain content without extra payment were seen negatively.

Engagement and loyalty were driven by the quality of updates and the communication from developers, the ladder being a surprising theme seen throughout the interviews. Extensive updates that significantly overhaul the game positively impacted perceptions and overall retention of interest in a title. However, skepticism regarding the initial state of the games was prominent among all participants. Primarily the stance that games are often released in an incomplete state, with subsequent updates and purchases fulfilling what should have been included with the initial purchase. Transparency in communication from the developers about upcoming updates and development plans was seen as crucial to maintaining trust with consumers. This transparency seemed to mitigate the negative sentiment about the initial state of titles and encouraged continued use.

Finally, purchase behaviour, in regards to available microtransactions, highlighted significant concerns about quality and economic value. Many participants felt that offerings within these full priced live service titles were overpriced, especially when considering the initial premium cost of the title. Overall, these perceptions of unfair pricing and predatory practices echoed in previous sections as well, were seen to detract from

the game's overall value. Not only preventing an initial purchase but also from continued use of a title. Participants clearly called for a balance in implementing these features, emphasizing the need for fair and transparent monetization practices. Participant 8 notably highlighted premium currencies as one of the more predatory practices. Overall, the need for a balanced approach to monetization was clearly established by participants, where additional offerings should enhance the experience without feeling as though they are limited without making that additional purchase.

5. Discussion

This section of the thesis addresses the two research questions developed and referenced in the introduction section of this thesis. Previous research was collected to develop context for already conducted research in relation to the questions. Primary data was then collected in order to explore potential answers based on the foundation established by conducted research. Here, we will discuss how the findings of this thesis connect to existing research.

5.1 Perception of hybrid models

When viewing the perceptions of the hybrid live service model its important to look at perceptions of GaaS as well. The core tenants of GaaS being a play-centric model featuring updates, recurring customer acquisition, retention, and monetization as discussed by Aleem, Capretz and Ahmed (2016) and Buboid & Weststar (2021). Their research found that this player-focus overall positively impacted digital game performance. However, under the lens of the hybrid model, the findings from the conducted interviews found similar though contradicting results. Participants in interviews appreciated the updates offered by titles under the hybrid model. However, their perception of the overall quality of the game was deemed underwhelming considering the premium initial cost associated with these titles. Furthermore, Aleem, Capretz and Ahmed (2016) found that the monetization from GaaS often surpassed earning from initial sales seen in more traditional GaaP titles. While under free-to-play GaaS titles this may be the case as there is no premium cost, with the premium initial cost under the hybrid model, interviews showed that the price of these titles negatively impacted the purchase intention

of users. Without making that initial purchase, consumers would not be able to take part in further monetization opportunities, efficiently removing the additional revenue streams associated with the business model.

Another aspect of the findings was that many of these titles were limiting the overall core experience without additional purchase, not only negatively impact the economic evaluation of titles but also lowering the perceived quality of them. This echoed Hamari et al.'s (2017) findings that developers have faced a dilemma when balancing high-quality services with creating a sufficient demand for the premium microtransactions. Responses from Participants clearly highlighted frustration with additional purchases that were deemed either pointless or predatory through the creation of paywalls for content and progression. Lehtonen, Vesa and Harviainen (2021) highlighted such aspects as well more specifically in term of designing play as labour, which was also discussed by Hamari (2010), however now there is an additional cost also associated with being able to access said content. Through the conducted interviews, such actions were seen to negatively influence the continued use of the title and the economic evaluation conducted by participants deemed continued purchases were not worthwhile.

Hamari's (2010) findings on marketing tactics employed by game developers presented in-game mediums of exchange as one tactic predominantly employed by developers. Interviews presented positive and negative views in relation to how these in-game mediums of exchange were implemented. More specifically, that they were seen as predatory due to the inconsistent value associated with them, especially if there was no way to earn it directly from gameplay. Additionally, interviews highlight the unfair pricing of the content as it was purely cosmetic in nature and provided no additional benefits toward their experience. However, participants did show disdain for purchases that gave other players a competitive edge compared to those who did not, echoing Hiemo et al. (2016) and Ball & Fordham's (2018) findings of such practices hurting sales and being deemed unethical, overall, calling attention to the need for balance in relation to how these additional monetization features need to be implemented. Moreover, through fair

pricing with a focus on additional value to the experience, overall, positive perceptions could be generated from developers.

5.2 Continuous developments influence on perceived value

The live service model, as described by Vauder and Heinze (2019), allows developers to release an unfinished product and, depending on its reception, refine and expand it through downloadable content and updates based on user feedback. While such practices may be optimal in a free to play GaaS title, the hybrid model discussed in this research found differing views from interviews. Specifically, the notion that the incomplete nature of the initial release lowered respondent's purchase intentions as the quality of the title is not deemed worth the premium prices. Furthermore, the economic evaluation conducted by participants deemed the unfinished nature as predatory due to the additional monetization within the tiles. Moreover, Petrovskaya and Zendle (2021) found such practices as predatory monetization through the delivery of a product that does not meet expectations. This aligns with the notions of the participants in the research of this thesis, reinforcing the idea that such practices can be seen as exploitative.

While the unfinished nature of titles under the hybrid model did negatively affect participants' perceived value, updates, and continuous development as a whole created positive feelings toward the continuous use of participants. This mirrors Theodora and Napitupulu's (2023) findings on events in games in which the content releases or updates associated with them created additional engagement and increased the perceived credibility of the developers. Participants shared similar sentiments, though they highlighted the need for transparency in relation to what features were actively being developed. Overall, such features seen through continuous development were met with positive reactions towards continuous use and purchase intention of titles under the hybrid live service model.

Furthermore, the hybrid model was found to create opportunities for co-creation with users by Hussain et al. (2023) through enhanced gaming features, superior game functionality, competitive game design, personalization, and self-indulgence based on listening to their feedback. Similar findings were seen by Vauder and Heinze (2019), with

additional value being generated through communication with the community. This study found that such co-creation aspects were critical in enhancing user engagement and satisfaction, reflecting positively on the perceived quality and social value of games under the hybrid model. More specifically in relation to continuous use intentions. As mentioned above, participants emphasized the importance of transparency in development and the need for developers to actively listen and respond to player feedback, which aligns with the principles outlined by Vauder and Heinze (2019).

5.6 Main Findings and Recommendations

The research questions established in the introduction section of this thesis will answer the main findings clearly and definitively. Additionally, recommendations for best practices and pitfalls to avoid will be given.

1. How do consumers perceive the value of games offered under the hybrid live service model?

Consumers' perceptions of the value of games under the live service model presented a multifaceted view influenced by various factors of perceived value, including enjoyment, social value, perceived quality, and economic value. Findings from conducted interviews indicated a mixed reception towards these titles and their features.

Participants place a high value on the core experience of titles, primarily gameplay, indicating enjoyable gameplay significantly influenced their purchase intentions and continued use of a title. Enjoyment as a driver for perceived value emerged as a crucial aspect of delivery from developers, highlighting the importance of providing a fun and engaging experience throughout each aspect of a title. Furthermore, social value through interaction with friends was not seen to directly influence purchase behaviour but did influence continued use of a product, as participants noted it enhanced their overall enjoyment of their gaming experience, thereby supporting purchase intention through sustained entertainment of the core experience.

Quality concerning hybrid live service models varied between participants. A general feeling of appreciation was seen for seasonal updates and improvements that added value to the core game, increasing engagement and perceived quality. However, the initial quality of titles needed to be completed, negatively impacting purchase intentions as a title's economic value and quality did not meet the high premium purchase. Moreover, transparency in the development and future maintenance of titles was critical in maintaining trust and encouraging continued use after a subpar release. Participants strongly express a desire for developers to communicate their plans through a roadmap, being transparent in the current state of a title and their development plans.

Finally, economic value creates a significant disconnect between developers and consumers. Participants expressed frustration over the high initial cost of what was often seen as an unfinished title, with additional high-cost in-game purchases. The financial burden of which was seen to diminish the overall quality of a title, leading to negative perception, affecting not only purchase intention but continued use as well. Moreover, the additional purchase provides little value to the core experience, in fact, even preventing complete enjoyment of a title without having made additional purchases. The combination of a high premium initial cost and ongoing monetization was frequently perceived as unfair and predatory, especially when the core experience was perceived as underwhelming, undermining the perceived economic value of the title.

2. How does the release of games as unfinished goods with promises of continued development influence consumers' perceptions of value and their subsequent trust and loyalty towards game developers and publishers?

Releasing unfinished games with the promise of future updates had significant implications for consumer perceptions of value, trust, and loyalty. The general view from participants was negative, as participants felt that it detracted from the quality of the game. The high initial cost of such titles, coupled with experiences considered underdeveloped, created a negative perception, with consumers feeling they were paying a premium for an early access version of the game. Fostering skepticism in respondents led many to

delay purchases until they could gauge feedback from others on the games' state post-release. There was a notable preference for smaller, independent developers perceived as more committed to delivering a complete and polished experience from the start. This skepticism often points towards more prominent developers and publishers, who were seen as prioritizing profits over delivering a complete and polished experience. Transparency from developers about the state of a title and upcoming updates was crucial in mitigating some of the negative perceptions of an incomplete title. Clear and honest communication helped maintain both trust and encouraged continued use even if the initial status of a game was deemed unsatisfactory. Participants further appreciated it when developers actively listened to player feedback and incorporated it into future updates, reinforcing a sense of community and co-creation.

While initial perceptions were often negative, the promise and delivery of meaningful updates could enhance long-term engagement and loyalty. Participants appreciated it when developers heard their concerns and incorporated necessary content and fixes at no additional cost. This responsiveness helps not only rebuild trust but also fosters a loyal fan base that continues to engage in a title. However, the overall success of hybrid live service titles requires a balance in the initial quality of a product, fair monetization practices, and transparent communication with the game's community. Collectively, these factors shape consumers' perceived value, trust, and loyalty and influence their purchase behaviour and continued use intentions.

This study's findings highlight several crucial factors that influence consumer perceptions, trust, and loyalty in the hybrid live service model for video games. To aid developers and publishers in navigating the new paradigm they have established within the industry, the following table presents best practices and pitfalls to avoid when implementing the hybrid live service model. The guidelines are derived from the analysis of participant feedback and aim to balance initial product quality, ongoing updates, transparent communication, and fair monetization practices.

Table 3: Best Practices and Pitfalls to Avoid in adopting the hybrid live service model

Best Practices	Pitfalls to Avoid
Prioritize an Enjoyable Experience - Ensure the core experience is engaging to drive purchase intentions and continued use.	Release Unfinished product - Avoid launching titles that feel incomplete or underdeveloped, as this negatively impacts perception.
Provide Seasonal Updates - Offer regular, meaningful updates to enhance the products quality and maintain engagement.	Neglect Initial Quality - Do not rely on future updates to compensate for a lack of quality at launch.
Be Transparent and Communicative - Clearly communicate development plans and maintain transparency about the services state and future updates.	Implement Predatory Monetization - Avoid high-cost additional purchases essential for a complete experience, as this is seen as unfair.
Engage with the Community - Listen to player feedback and incorporate it into future updates to build trust and loyalty.	Overpromise and Underdeliver - Do not make promises about updates or content that you cannot deliver, as this erodes trust.
Offer Fair Monetization Practices - Ensure that any additional purchases add genuine value to the experience without being essential.	Ignore User Feedback - Avoid disregarding user feedback, leading to dissatisfaction and reduced loyalty.
Balance Initial and Ongoing Value - Strive to provide fair value for the initial purchase and ongoing updates to maintain a positive perception of economic value.	Create Economic Burdens - Avoid pricing strategies that make the service feel like a financial burden, diminishing overall enjoyment.

5.7 Implications for Information System Science

Though this research primarily covers the videogame industry, several significant implications for information systems science can be extracted from the findings, particularly in the context of digital product development and consumer engagement with service-oriented business models. The findings of this thesis emphasize the importance

of understanding consumer perceptions of hybrid models that provide traditional product offerings with ongoing service elements. Regarding information systems, this highlights the importance of having robust frameworks that can accurately capture and analyze feedback—developing systems that facilitate continuous feedback integration for both adaptive and responsive development cycles, aiding in maintaining consumer trust and enhancing satisfaction through aligning updates with user expectations and preferences.

The findings of this thesis emphasized the critical role of transparency and communication, suggesting that information systems should prioritize features that support clean and honest communication with users. To enhance trust and loyalty, systems designed to provide detailed updates on product development, upcoming features, and bug fixes should be implemented. The negative perceptions associated with high initial costs combined with ongoing monetization strategies indicate a need for information systems to balance revenue generation with user experience. Information systems can contribute to this balance by developing pricing models considering user satisfaction and perceived value. Leveraging data analytic systems can adjust strategies to optimize a system's profitability and user retention, avoiding potential views of predatory practices.

5.8 Limitations

The most glaring limitation of this study comes from the demographic selected for the conducted interviews. As convenience sampling was chosen as a means for participant selection, an apparent disparity in terms of the diversity of selected participants can be seen. Firstly, all participants interviewed were male, which, according to the Entertainment Software Association 2023 *Essential Facts about the Video Game Industry* report, only represents about half of players, as 46% of players identify as female (Entertainment Software Association, 2023). The impact that gender has on such purchases could have produced varied findings, which should be analyzed in future research. Furthermore, all respondents were either Finnish or American; more diversity between nationality and culture could prevent a wider variety in how other cultures purchase titles under the hybrid live service model. Finally, all participants were all

between the age of 20-27, removing the potential of seeing how older consumers view hybrid live service models. These limitations stem from the fact that this is an independently written Master's thesis, lacking the funding to find a larger demographic for interviews. If financial limitations were not in place, a larger demographic could have been acquired for the purpose of this study.

5.9 Suggestions for further research

This study provided a surface-level analysis of how consumer value perception was affected by the emergence of hybrid live service titles. However, the findings and implications of this thesis open several avenues for future research in the field of information system science and digital product development. For example, Longitudinal studies of the long-term effects of the hybrid live service model, viewing initial reactions, and the eventual development of a title would identify practices that maintain user satisfaction without negatively impacting perceived value, investigating various communication strategies taken by developers such as community blogs, forums, or in-game messages, providing guidelines for efficient community management. Ethical implications of monetization practices also warrant deeper investigation, focusing on monetization practices commonly employed by developers and the potential psychological effects of monetization. Future research can enhance our understanding of consumer behaviour, digital product development, and service-oriented business models by addressing these areas.

5.5 Summary of Discussion

The exploration of the hybrid live service model within the video game industry reveals a multifaceted influence on perceived value where continuous development and player engagement clash with monetization and initial product quality. The findings discussed within this section highlight the inherent challenges associated with adopting this evolving model.

The general perception of the hybrid live service model, as reflected in the interviews, presents a mixed reception. While participants appreciated the regular updates and

ongoing development that extends the lifecycle of titles, the initial release of unfinished products at a premium price significantly impacted their perceived value, especially concerning the economic value and quality of the title. This was particularly prominent when additional monetization strategies were layered on top, often leading to participants perceiving the titles as predatory and diminishing the quality of their gaming experience. These sentiments from the interviews align with the prior research conducted by Hamari, et al. (2017) and Petrovskaya and Zendle (2021), highlighting a critical need for balance in monetization practices to avoid alienating consumers.

Continuous development was seen to influence user engagement and loyalty in a positive manner, provided that updates were meaningful, and the developers were transparent in the process. These findings supported the notion that regular content releases can enhance the perceived credibility of developers, as noted by Theodora and Napitupulu's (2023) research. However, the initial negative impact of releasing unfinished products must be noticed due to its negative influence on purchase intentions. While Vauder and Heinze (2019) stated the benefit of releasing an unfinished product in order to gauge reception, the core product provided at launch needs to be polished and provide what was stated, especially with the initial premium purchase. Furthermore, the hybrid model's capacity for co-creation with users emerged as a significant advantage. Listening to player feedback and integrating it into the game through subsequent updates not only improves the gameplay experience but also fosters a stronger sense of community and loyalty. This aligns with the principles discussed by Vauder and Heinze (2019) and Hussain et al. (2023), emphasizing the importance of community engagement in enhancing the perceived quality and social value of games.

While the hybrid model offers promising avenues for extending game lifecycles and increasing player engagement through continuous updates and community involvement, it also presents substantial risks if not implemented carefully. To efficiently leverage the benefits of this model, it lies in maintaining a fair balance between the core aspects of the model. More specifically, a balance between initial product quality, monetization strategies, and transparent, meaningful engagement with the player community. Future

research and industry practices should continue to explore and refine these aspects to optimize both player satisfaction and business success in the evolving landscape of the video game industry.

6. CONCLUSION

The research conducted in this thesis provides a comprehensive evaluation of the hybrid live service model's impact on consumer value perceptions within the video game industry. The findings highlight the multifaceted nature of consumer value, influenced by dimensions such as enjoyment, social value, quality, and economic evaluations. Through a detailed analysis of consumer Behaviour and perceptions conducted through semi-structured interviews, this study reveals both opportunities and challenges developers and publishers face by integrating GaaS features into full-priced titles. The model has been shown to enhance player engagement and extend the life cycle of games through continuous updates and community involvement. However, it can also lead to dissatisfaction, especially when released in an incomplete state, compromising the quality of monetization strategies that are perceived as predatory. Maintaining a balanced approach in implementing these features is vital for maintaining the trust and satisfaction of the consumer.

This thesis presents the importance of transparent communication and meaningful engagement with the player community. Developers who listen to player feedback and incorporate it into subsequent updates can foster a stronger sense of community and loyalty. Inversely, the release of a product that is considered unfinished at a premium price can severely damage consumer perceptions and hinder both purchase intentions and the continued use of a title. Overall, the insights gained from this thesis's research are relevant to the video game industry and offer valuable insights for other sectors adopting similar service-oriented models. Further research should continue exploring the dynamics of optimizing satisfaction and business success within a digital marketplace. By understanding and addressing factors influencing consumer value perceptions, developers and publishers can better understand the pitfalls of implementing a hybrid live service model, fostering a more consumer-friendly product.

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Appendices

Interview Questions

General intro questions

1. What is your name?
2. What is your age?
3. What is your preferred gender?

General Experience

4. How long have you played video games for?
5. How often do you play video games, and what types of games do you usually play?
    a. What generates interest in a title for you?
6. Can you list some of the full-priced games you have played that include GaaS features?

Perceptions of Hybrid Model

7. What is your reaction to full priced titles that include GaaS features?
    a. What about seasonal updates or microtransactions?
8. What do you think about games that you pay full price for and then keep getting new stuff added to them for free?

Impact of Monetization Strategies

9. Have you ever purchased additional content such as DLCs, microtransactions, or a season pass for any of these games? If so, what motivated your purchase?
10. How do you feel about the pricing of in-game content in these full-priced games? Do you think they offer fair value for the money?
    a. What about for free to play games?
11. In games where you've encountered microtransactions, how transparent do you find the pricing and the impact of purchases on gameplay?

Consumer Engagement and Satisfaction

12. How do ongoing updates and new content releases affect your interest and engagement in a game over time?

13. Can you describe a positive experience you've had with a game that regularly updates its content?
    a. What about a negative experience?
14. How does the addition of GaaS features impact your loyalty to a game or brand?

Quality and Completion

15. Have you ever felt that a full-priced game was released unfinished but promised to improve over time through updates?
    a. How did this impact your perception of the game?
16. What are your expectations for the quality and completeness of a game when you pay full price at launch?

Community Interaction

17. How important is the game's community in your decision to keep playing? Do GaaS features like community events influence your participation?
18. How well do you think game developers communicate with players about upcoming updates or changes in game features?

Ethical Considerations

19. Have you ever felt pressured to make in-game purchases to remain competitive or to fully enjoy a game?

Future Expectations

20. What changes would you like to see in how full priced live service titles are developed, market, maintained?
21. Are there any features or practices in full priced live service that you think should be adopted more widely?
    a. Or avoided altogether